

INBRIEF



Punjab govt. sheltering drug peddlers, says Union Minister

Hitting out at the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government in Punjab, Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Monday said the party has failed to eradicate drug menace despite Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann repeatedly setting deadlines to end drug addiction. “Those deadlines kept dying one after another,” he said while addressing a gathering at Talwandi Sabo in Bathinda district as he flagged off the fourth ‘Nasha Mukht Punjab Yatra’. The Union Minister alleged that Punjab is drowning in the quagmire of drugs. “AAP is running a government of crime, corruption and commission in Punjab and is engaged in the work of providing protection to drug peddlers,” said Mr. Chouhan.

J&K govt. dismisses school teacher over POCSO case

The J&K government on Monday invoked provisions of Article 311 to terminate the service of a government schoolteacher allegedly involved in the rape of a 14-year-old girl in Kishtwar district. The victim died on August 20 during “a forced abortion procedure”. The order also disqualified the terminated teacher from any future employment in government service in J&K. He faced charges under Sections 61(2), 65(1), 90, 91 and 92 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023, and Sections 4, 6, 8, 10 and 17 of the POCSO Act, 2012.

100% drought likely to be declared in Maharashtra by month-end: Minister

Never seen such severe dry spell, says Cooperation Minister Babasaheb Patil; State has initiated student fee waivers, electricity bill reductions and water tanker deployments in response, he adds

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Maharashtra Cooperation Minister Babasaheb Patil on Monday said the BJP-led Mahayuti government will soon declare 100% drought in the State. Speaking on the severity of the crisis, Mr. Patil said, “In my entire life, I have never seen such a severe drought. All crops, including soya bean, cotton and sugarcane, have suffered due to the dry spell and the loss is huge. The 100% drought declaration is expected by the end of September based on the National Disaster Response Fund norms.”

The Minister said the government has already initiated measures such as fee waiver for students, electricity bill waiver, and deployment of water tankers to provide relief.

The statement assumes significance as it is the first time a Minister has spoken of a 100% drought declaration. So far, the official po-



A farmer in Umarga taluka of Dharashiv district letting his cattle graze on his crop that has withered due to the dry spell. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

sition of the government has been that crop damage surveys and ground verification would be conducted after October 5.

Several regions in the State have been facing a prolonged dry spell, causing extensive crop loss and forcing farmers to incur heavy losses. According to the State Agriculture Department, rainfall has remained absent for over 20 days in at least 83 talukas across 20 districts. At least six districts, including Am-

ravati, Solapur and Latur, have recorded rainfall deficit of 40-50%. Water tankers have started plying in villages such as Naichakur in Dharashiv district.

Advisory to districts

In view of the crisis, the State government has instructed district administrations to revive existing water sources and build water supply networks in villages facing shortage instead of treating tankers as the first solution.

A circular issued by the State Soil and Water Conservation Department on September 16 stated that the Groundwater Surveys and Development Agency will identify villages with drinking water shortage and submit the list to District Collectorates by October. District Collectors will have to plan interventions for the villages for the period between October and December. The plans are to be submitted by November 15, followed by plans for January-March 2027 by December 20, and for April-June 2027 by January 20, it stated.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday said the government would not wait for Central assistance to help farmers facing distress due to inadequate rainfall. “A formal crop loss assessment would be carried out after October 5 as required under the rules, following which the State would seek assistance from the Centre,” he told reporters.

BJP, Cong. workers clash during Assam bypoll campaign

Press Trust of India
NAGAON

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Congress workers clashed during campaigning for the Nagaon Lok Sabha by-election in Assam on Monday, police said.

The incident happened around 4 p.m. in the Samaguri Assembly segment when a Congress procession, led by the party's State president Gaurav Gogoi, was on the way to a public meeting at Larimukh.

Dhubri MP Rakibul Husain, former Chhattisgarh CM Bhupesh Baghel and the party's bypoll candidate Sibamoni Bora were also present in the procession.

Police said BJP supporters had gathered at Bara Bazar to show black flags to the Congress leaders. “As around 30 to 40 Congress workers on motorcycles passed the area, slogans like ‘Gaurav Gogoi Go Back, Congress Go Back, Rakibul Go Back’ were raised, leading to tension,” an officer said.

When the Congress convoy returned through the same route after the meeting, suspected BJP supporters pelted stones at the



Congress leader K.C. Venugopal says the BJP is ‘desperately shaken’ by his party's campaign

Opposition party's vehicles, he said.

Police said Congress workers then returned to the spot with sticks, further escalating the situation, with both sides hurling stones at each other.

Journalists injured

The glass of two Congress vehicles was broken. Some journalists also sustained minor injuries in the stone-pelting, they said.

All India Congress Committee general secretary (Organisation) K.C. Venugopal said that after West Bengal BJP's “murder of democracy”, CM Sarma has sent “his goons to finish off” his political rivals.

He claimed that the ruling BJP is “desperately shaken” by the Congress leaders and their campaign.

Jain monk to resume protest if Dadar Kabutarkhana not opened for pigeon feeding

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

Jain monk Nileschandra Vijay on Monday accused State Skill Development Minister Mangal Prabhat Lodha of “suppressing” the voice of the Jain community in the Dadar Kabutarkhana issue and warned of protests if the pigeon-feeding enclosure is not opened. “He is suppressing the voice of the Jain community. I spoke to State Assembly Speaker Rahul Narvekar and told him if the issue is not resolved, I will stage a protest outside the Godiji Parshwanath Jain temple in Mumbai's Paydhuni,” he said.

The monk has been demanding the publication of any existing government or municipal policy banning pigeon or bird feeding, else



Nileschandra Vijay

an immediate clarification be issued that feeding is not prohibited at areas demarcated by the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC). On November 3 last year, he had staged a hunger strike at Mumbai's Azad Maidan demanding the restoration of Dadar Kabutarkhana. He ended the protest after Mr. Lodha had assured him of taking the matter to Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and finding a solution.

Earlier, the Bombay High Court had ordered

that feeding be allowed only at four BMC-suggested spots between 7 a.m. and 9 a.m.: the Worli Hill reservoir, the mangrove area on Lokhandwala Back Road in Andheri West, the Airolimulund check post area, and Gorai ground in Borivali West.

The monk disapproved of these alternative sites as these are as far as four to nine kilometres away and alleged that “builders and a few greedy politicians are lobbying for political gains”. He said he would also write to the CM. “All I want justice for these innocent creatures,” he said.

The Dadar Kabutarkhana issue reached Bombay HC after the issue of human deaths due to exposure to pigeon droppings surfaced in July.

SBSP president Rajbhar claims U.P. will be divided into four parts after caste census

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Cabinet Minister and Suheldev Bhartiya Samaj Party (SBSP) president Om Prakash Rajbhar on Monday claimed that the State will be divided into four parts soon and Purvanchal region will get a Chief Minister from the Rajbhar community, reviving an issue that crops up every few years.

While the BJP played down the issue, the Congress hit out at Narendra Modi over “doublespeak” as Mr. Rajbhar referred to a conversation with the PM on division of the State. The principal Opposition party, Samajwadi Party (SP), said it is “fundamentally opposed” to any such division.

“Once the caste census is completed, there will be no problem in carrying out the division. We will divide



Om Prakash Rajbhar

the State after the caste census. This is what the Prime Minister of the country said,” claimed Mr. Rajbhar while addressing a public meeting in Ambedkarnagar district, without specifying when and where he had the conversation. “The day a separate Purvanchal state is created, the first Chief Minister will be a son of the Rajbhar community. When the State is divided, there

will be Purvanchal, Madhyanchal, Bundelkhand and Harit Pradesh. The Rajbhar community has the largest vote base in Purvanchal,” he added.

The U.P. government led by Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) had passed a proposal in the Assembly to divide the State into four parts before the 2012 election but failed to get the Central government's approval.

The Congress alleged that the Mr. Rajbhar is indulging in fresh theatrics to remain relevant in eastern U.P. as his own community is drifting towards the INDIA alliance. “In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, the Rajbhars supported the INDIA alliance. The community understands that Om Prakash Rajbhar has done nothing for the region, hence they are supporting the SP-Congress alliance. The PM must clarify

on the claim,” said Shah Nawaz Alam, Congress national secretary.

“We are fundamentally against the division of Uttar Pradesh. Instead of speaking about the development work they have done in the last 10 years, such a statement highlights that the NDA has nothing to present before the public,” said SP spokesperson Sunil Singh Yadav ‘Sajan’.

‘Long-pending demand’

Devesh Chaubey, who is associated with Purvanchal Vikas Parishad, said the demand for a separate Purvanchal is a long-pending one. “We are happy that Om Prakash Rajbhar is raising the issue. The economic and social dynamics of eastern U.P. are fundamentally different from western U.P. We hope the demand for division will reach its logical conclusion,” he said.

Next rural poll only after delimitation, says Bihar CM

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Monday said the next panchayat election will be conducted only after the process of delimitation is completed. He made the remark while addressing a programme on ‘Gram Sansad - Bihar Chapter’ where detailed discussions were held on rural development, the role of Panchayats and various ways to make villages self-reliant and developed.

A large number of mukhiyas and sarpanches attended the event, including State president of Mukhiya Sangh Mithilesh Rai, State president of Panch-Sarpanch Sangh Amod Nirala and founder and general secretary of Gram Sansad Brajesh Sharma.

Suggestions invited

Mr. Choudhary said that three-tier panchayat representatives play a crucial role in the State's development. He urged the panchayat representatives to offer suggestions on improving village infrastructure.

Accompanied with Gram Sansad national president Sanjay Mayukh, Mr. Choudhary said the panchayat is the most vital unit of democracy and panchayat mukhiyas (village head) bears the important responsibility of developing their area and resolving public grievances.

He called upon the ‘Gram Sansad’ to suggest new revenue sources at the panchayat level to improve basic amenities in villages, such as waste management, drinking water, electricity, and roads. He added that the government is not in favour of imposing additional taxes on the common people. He said work would be undertaken to establish a panchayat for a population of 7,500 and an engineering cell will be set up within the Panchayati Raj Department.

BJP sweeps mayoral polls in Rajasthan; Cong. cries foul

Mohammed Iqbal
JAIPUR

After emerging as the largest party in the urban local body elections held recently, the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in Rajasthan on Monday won the mayoral contests in six of the seven major municipal corporations. The party secured the mayoral posts in Ajmer and Pali despite the Congress securing more seats of councillors in both the towns.

The BJP defeated the Congress in Alwar, Udaipur, Pali and Ajmer, while its candidates were elected unopposed in Bharatpur and Bhilwara. The only consolation for Congress came in Bikaner, where it retained the mayoral post with the election of Anil Kalla.

Of the 309 urban bodies in Rajasthan, elections to the top posts were held in 273 on Monday. Chairpersons were earlier elected



Security personnel keeping a strict vigil during the Ajmer Municipal Corporation mayoral poll on Monday. ANI

unopposed in some other bodies, while elections in the Jaipur, Jodhpur and Kota Municipal Corporations and Kota district's Suket municipality will be held on September 25.

Even as the BJP strengthened its position in the urban areas, the Opposition Congress accused the State government of misusing the police and administration to ensure the victory of the ruling party's candidates. Pradesh Congress president Govind Singh Dotasra said

the senior party leaders were subjected to “coercive police action and abusive behaviour”.

Mr. Dotasra alleged that the BJP had used police force to pressure the Congress councillors and Independents into helping the party form the boards in several towns. Both the BJP and the Congress had moved their councillors to hotels and resorts ahead of voting to prevent poaching and secure the support of Independents.

The Congress suffered a setback in Pali, where it finished third despite emerging as the largest party. BJP candidate Namita Bubukia won the mayoral election with 33 votes, narrowly defeating Congress rebel Rajbala Hingad, who secured 29. The official Congress candidate received only three votes.

In Ajmer, the BJP's Anamika Sharma was elected mayor with 43 votes, while the Congress received 37 votes. The BJP, whose 32 councillors were elected in the local body polls, secured the support of 11 Independents.

BJP candidate Paras Singhvi was elected the mayor in Udaipur, having secured 55 votes, while Suman Lata Agrawal of the party was elected the mayor in Alwar. Congress leader Anil Kalla, nephew of former Minister B.D. Kalla, was elected mayor in Bikaner, where the party had

won 42 of the 80 wards, crossing the majority mark on its own.

AAP wins in Baran

The BJP candidates were elected as heads in 32 of the 47 municipal councils and in 162 of the 252 municipalities. The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) formed its first Municipal Council board in Baran, while its candidate Sheetal Rathore was elected the chairperson.

The Congress pointed out that the High Court had to intervene by issuing directives to ensure safe arrival of Congress and Congress-backed councillors in various urban bodies for casting their votes. The High Court constituted special benches and held hearings late on Sunday night and Monday morning - both days being holidays - to consider urgent petitions seeking protection from arrest for councillors and candidates.

Cancel TVK's list of star campaigners from other parties, DMK urges EC

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK organisation secretary R.S. Bharathi on Monday submitted a complaint to the Election Commission of India (EC), urging it to immediately cancel the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam's (TVK) list of star campaigners from other political parties for the byelections to the Madurantakam and Dharapuram Assembly constituencies. The DMK said this went against the provisions of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, and the model code of conduct.

The TVK had named Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) president Manickam Tagore, Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) leader Thol. Thirumavalavan, Minister Vanni

Arasu (VCK), D. Ravikumar (VCK MP), senior VCK leader Sinthanai Selvan, Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (MDMK) general secretary Vaiko, party MP Durai Vaiko, and Indian Union Muslim League (IUM) leader K.M. Kader Mohideen as its star campaigners.

In his complaint to Tamil Nadu CEO Archana Patnaik, Mr. Bharathi said Section 77(1) of the Representation of the People Act used the expressions, ‘leaders of a political party’ and ‘of that political party’ while providing for the exemption of their travel expenses from the election expenditure accounts of candidates. “... A political party can designate only its own leaders and office-bearers as star campaigners,” he said.



INBRIEF



Flight to Frankfurt diverted, terminated due to smell

A direct flight from Bengaluru to Frankfurt in Germany on Sunday was diverted to Mumbai and terminated due to an unusual smell emanating from the aircraft cabin. German carrier Lufthansa, which operates the daily non-stop flight, was scheduled to depart from the Kempegowda International Airport around 3 a.m. on Sunday. However, the departure was delayed by three-and-a-half hours. On the way, the flight was diverted to Mumbai due to the smell and later terminated.

17 injured as giant honeybees swarm KSRTC bus in Keralam

Seventeen persons were injured after a swarm of giant honeybees attacked bus passengers near the tourist spot of Gavi in Pathanamthitta district on Monday. The incident occurred in the Periyar Tiger Reserve. The KSRTC bus had 58 people on board, including the crew. When it passed Gavi, the driver stopped on a narrow stretch to give way to a car. In an instant, bees surged into the bus and stung the passengers. The injured were taken to the nearby hospitals for treatment.

4 injured as armed gang goes on stabbing spree in Bengaluru

An armed gang of unidentified men went on a stabbing spree at several locations at Uttarahalli in Bengaluru on Sunday night, injuring at least four people, in seemingly unprovoked attacks. According to the police, around 9 p.m., six to seven men on motorcycles, armed with machetes, attacked four friends standing by the roadside. They then attacked bystanders near a fish stall. The police have identified four suspects and detained a few others for investigation.

SC orders fresh probe into 2012 Karnataka rape-murder

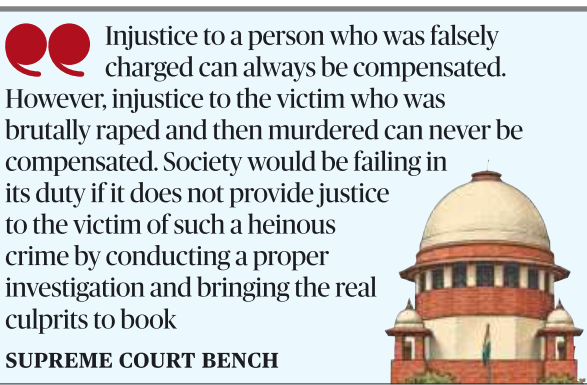
Top court tells State to constitute a tech-savvy SIT without any officer from the old investigation team and complete probe in 3 months; lone accused in case was acquitted by CBI court in 2023

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday ordered fresh investigation into the 2012 brutal rape and murder of a 17-year-old near the bathing ghat on the outskirts of Dharmasthala in Karnataka while expressing shock at the botched-up probe into the incident.

A fresh investigation should be concluded within a period of three months and the police report shall be filed before the court concerned, the court said on a petition from the victim's mother.

The lone accused in the case, Santosh Rao, was acquitted by a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI)



court in June 2023.

"Injustice to a person who was falsely charged can always be compensated. However, injustice to the victim who was brutally raped and then murdered can never be compensated. Society would be failing in its duty if it does not provide justice to the victim of such a heinous crime by conducting a proper investigation and bringing the real culprits to book



the victim of such a heinous crime by conducting a proper investigation and bringing the real culprits to book," a Bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva observed. "Investigation must be fair, transparent and judicious as it is the minimum requirement of rule of law.

The investigating agency cannot be permitted to conduct an investigation in a tainted and biased manner," the judgment said.

The court directed the Karnataka government to constitute a tech-savvy Special Investigation Team (SIT) headed by a senior police officer. No officer who was part of the earlier team must be in the SIT.

The petitioner-mother was represented by senior advocates Shobha Gupta and Sanjay Nuli.

Kasturirangan report on Western Ghats threatens livelihoods: Karnataka CM

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Monday told the Legislative Assembly that the proposed implementation of the Kasturirangan Committee report could threaten the livelihoods of people in 10 districts, even as he reaffirmed the State government's commitment to protecting the livelihoods

of farmers and residents of the Western Ghats.

During the debate on the report, Mr. Shivakumar said its recommendations had created "an atmosphere of fear" among farmers. "More than six rivers originate and flow through the Western Ghats. The proposal of unscientific measures has caused widespread anxiety regarding people's livelihoods," he said. Before attending

the session, Mr. Shivakumar had toured the coastal and Malnad regions, which would be affected by the report, and had held meetings with people.

According to the Kasturirangan report, 20,668 sq. km of Karnataka's Western Ghats region has been identified as ecologically sensitive, covering 1,449 villages. Mr. Shivakumar said people and farmers had made several sugges-

tions during his consultations. "Farmers have sought rejection of the report and have demanded that a new committee be constituted. They have also urged that the Ecologically Sensitive Zone classification be scrapped and the Keralam model adopted," he said.

The Centre has asked Karnataka to convey its decision on the report by September 27.



Seeking support: Representatives of fishermen's organisations with DMK president M.K. Stalin on Monday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

DMK chief warns of protest against new Secretariat plan

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin on Monday warned that his party would join hands with fishermen's organisations and launch a massive protest if the Tamil Nadu government remained "arrogant" and went ahead with its proposal to build a new Secretariat at Pattinapakkam, a coastal habitat, in Chennai.

In a statement, he said the TVK-led government should pay heed to the "cries of fishermen" and withdraw the order for the construction of a new Secretariat at Pattinapakkam. "Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay should announce the government's decision, and construct houses for the fishermen in the area," he said, after representatives of fishermen's organisations met him and sought his support.

Mr. Stalin said the TVK government's "unilateral decision" to construct a new Secretariat, "which would destroy the habita-

tion and livelihood of fishermen", was condemnable.

Several alternatives Mr. Stalin said there were several other places where a new Secretariat could be built.

"The Omandurar Government Estate, where a new Secretariat was constructed [during the Karunanidhi government], is also available. If necessary, the super-speciality hospital could be shifted to another location, and the premises could be used as a Secretariat. But there are reports that the government has chosen Pattinapakkam because astrologers have advised that the Chief Minister's office face the sea," he said.

Mr. Stalin said he thought the proposal would not materialise as the two Communist parties extending outside support to the government were opposed to it. "But it is shocking that the TVK government is stubborn in its stand," he said.

Bolarum arms theft accused sent to 10-day police custody

Naveen Kumar
HYDERABAD

A Secunderabad court has granted the Hyderabad police 10 days' custody of retired Army Havildar U. Mallesh, accused in the theft of firearms and ammunition from the 20 Battalion, Madras Regiment, in Bolarum. His questioning will begin on Tuesday. Investigators are expected to question Mallesh about the theft, his motive and the possible involvement of others. However, he is reported to have claimed that he acted alone.

An officer from Bolarum police said various agencies involved in the investigation could also question Mallesh during the custody



Telangana DGP, along with senior officers, examines the stolen arms and ammunition.

period. He will be questioned by the Malkajgiri police at the Bolarum police station. However, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) could also take him to its headquarters in Hyderabad for questioning, the officer said.

Officials have advised that his medical condition should be taken into consideration during the custody period and that a medical officer should be available during questioning. Mallesh was earlier shifted from Chanchalguda jail to a hospital after liver and kidney complications were detected during a routine medical examination following his remand.

The case pertains to the theft of 12 firearms and more than 1,800 rounds of ammunition on the night of August 30. The police alleged that Mallesh entered the premises, broke open the Kote and removed the firearms and matching ammunition. He was arrested on September 11.

Rare sighting



On the prowl: A black panther, the melanistic colour variant of the leopard (Panthera pardus), was spotted in the Coimbatore forest range along the Western Ghats on Monday. M. PERIASAMY

Karnataka HC constitutes SIT to probe KPSC 'irregularities'

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka High Court on Monday ordered a court-monitored investigation – by constituting a Special Investigation Team (SIT) headed by senior IPS officer and Director-General of Police Alok Kumar – into the alleged irregularities in the recruitment processes conducted by the Karnataka State Public Service Commission (KPSC).

While giving 100 days for the SIT to complete the investigation and submit the final report, the court also directed it to submit an investigation progress report every 30 days.

Beyond blood ties: a Gen Z-built home in Keralam is offering the bonds of a family

Sam Paul A.
KOZHIKODE

A five-cent plot with a two-storey house at Thenhipalam in Malappuram is home to a family like any other. As the afternoon heat begins to subside, Achu (name changed), 7, is playing cricket with some of his "siblings" and other family members in the front courtyard.

This is a family without blood ties. Yet the eight children – whose lives were once marked by abandonment, trauma and uncertainty – now live with their "Amma" (mother) and three "chechis" (elder sisters/caregivers), sharing the bonds and rhythms of everyday family life under one roof.



Some of the children and caregivers at Rise Up Home, at Thenhipalam in Malappuram district. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Achu was brought to Rise Up Home (RUH) about six months ago following the intervention of the Malappuram district Child Welfare Committee. RUH, a pioneering initiative of the Gen Z-led, volunteer-driven Rise Up Forum (RUF), established in 2023

to provide children with the stability, dignity and affection of a family.

Like Achu, the youngest of the eight, his seven "siblings" study in classes up to Class X and take part in extracurricular activities. Their three caregiver "chechis", also pursue their stu-

dies and careers, while the group lives together with their elderly "Amma", Santhakumari, who continues to pursue her passion for stitching. The caregivers and Santhakumari live full-time at RUH and provide their services voluntarily.

According to A. Mammu Master, chairperson of the Malappuram CWC, RUH at Thenhipalam is the first group foster-care home in the State. "Unlike conventional children's homes, children at RUH live in a much more family-based setting, both in terms of their environment and socialisation. What makes this initiative particularly encouraging is that it is being run by a group of young people," says Mr. Mammu.

Research team documents 3,261 flowering plant species in Agasthyamalai reserve

Tiki Rajwi
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A new checklist of flowering plants in south India's Agasthyalamalai Biosphere Reserve (ABR), compiled by the Jawaharlal Nehru Tropical Botanic Garden and Research Institute (JNTBGR) in Thiruvananthapuram, seeks to reaffirm the global significance of the Western Ghats as a biodiversity hotspot and the need for focussed, region-specific strategies for protecting it.

The JNTBGR research team documented 3,261 species, 26 sub-species and 28 varieties belonging to 1,139 genera and 190 families in the ABR.

The astonishing heft of the ABR's floral wealth



Paphiopedilum druryi, an orchid endemic to Agasthyamalai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

upholds its position as "one of the most significant centres of angiosperm diversity and endemism in the Indian subcontinent".

Plant Science Today has published the 'Comprehensive checklist of the flowering plants of the Agas-

thyamalai Biosphere Reserve, South India' compiled by E.S. Santhosh Kumar, S.M. Shareef, P.P. Anusha, K.A. Rashmi and Rejitha Joseph of JNTBGR.

Spread over Keralam and Tamil Nadu, the "hill systems and vegetation of the ABR constitute a biologically unique, yet ecologically fragile landscape," the research paper accompanying the checklist noted.

The ABR is one of four biosphere reserves in south India.

In the ABR, Fabaceae is the most species-rich family with 349 taxa, followed by Rubiaceae (194), Poaceae (193) and Orchidaceae (168). A remarkably high level of endemism was recorded, with 1018 taxa (31.2

%) endemic to India, including 245 steno-endemic taxa (confined to highly specialised habitats).

'Sharing' with Sri Lanka According to the research team, the flora here reveal "strong" biogeographic affinity with Sri Lanka, with the two regions sharing 347 taxa.

Reasons may range from historical land connections during periods of lower sea level, shared Gondwanan history and long-term climatic similarities. Also interesting are 102 taxa displaying affinity with tropical American flora. This possibly reflects long-distance dispersal events or naturalisation after introduction by humans, the paper said.

Chargesheet against travel site promoter in betting app case

The Hindu Bureau
RAIPUR/NEW DELHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has filed a chargesheet against EaseMyTrip co-founder Nishant Pitti in the money laundering case related to Mahadev online betting app, accusing him of actively assisting another co-accused in layering the proceeds of crime through stock market manipulations.

According to the charge sheet filed in a special PMLA (Prevention of Money Laundering Act) court in Raipur on September 10, Mr. Pitti, on behalf of the promoters of Easy Trip Planners Ltd., the holding company of EaseMyTrip, entered into a pre-arranged stock price manipulation deal with a man named Amardeep Sharma to artificially inflate the share price and market capitalisation of Easy Trip Planners Ltd. The chargesheet described Mr. Sharma as an associate of Hari Shankar Tiberwal, a co-accused in the case. Earlier statements by the ED described Mr. Tiberwal as a hawala operator based in Dubai who was operating Skyexchange, an illegal betting platform.

Shares attached
Subsequent to this deal, Mr. Tiberwal's front, foreign portfolio investor (FPI) entity AG Dynamic

The chargesheet alleges that Nishant Pitti entered into a pre-arranged stock price manipulation deal to artificially inflate share price

Funds Ltd., purchased shares of Easy Trip Planners Ltd. at inflated valuations, according to investigators.

The ED is also said to have attached Mr. Pitti's demat (dematerialised) shares worth ₹59.60 crore.

Meanwhile, Mr. Pitti said that he was not aware of the filing of the chargesheet and maintained that all his assets had been obtained through lawful sources of income.

"I have always cooperated with and shall continue to cooperate with all law enforcement bodies. I shall submit detailed evidence to establish my *bona fide* conduct, in accordance with the procedure prescribed by law," Mr. Pitti said in a written response to a question for his reaction to the latest development.

"All my transactions comply with applicable laws, and all my assets have been obtained from lawful sources of income and through formal banking channels. I shall contest any insinuation to the contrary through the courts," Mr. Pitti said.

Class 10 girl and boy returning from coaching groped, assaulted in Bihar

Police register *suo motu* FIR, arrest three as viral video of crime sparks political row; NCW directs support for teens, says steps should be taken to stop video circulation; Rahul Gandhi slams patriarchy; Tejashwi says Bihar put to shame by NDA govt.

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Two Class 10 students, a girl and a boy, returning from a coaching class were allegedly groped and assaulted by a group of men in Jamui district of Bihar on Saturday. A video of the incident went viral on social media on Monday, prodding the police to register an FIR and arrest three people.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and other Opposition leaders said the incident was "deeply disturbing", indicative of the patriarchal attitudes among the supporters of the ruling BJP, and exposing the State's law-and-order situation.

The National Commission for Women (NCW) on Monday took *suo motu* cognisance of the alleged assault and harassment, and directed the Director-General of Police to immediately register an FIR. The State Commission for Women also took *suo motu* cognisance of the incident, and promised that strict action would be taken against those found guilty.

Three arrested so far
"There was no formal complaint registered by anyone against anyone in the incident," said Jamui Superintendent of Police Vishwajit



Dayal. "The police took *suo motu* cognisance of the incident and approached the girl and her friend, a boy. Both were returning from a hillside area after their coaching was over on the Jamui-Lakhisarai road where a group of six to seven people, some even masked, stopped them as it is shown in the viral video and they were being harassed on September 19 evening around 7 p.m.," he added.

An FIR (No 428/ 2026) was registered over the incident at Jamui police station. All the people seen in the viral video were taken into custody and three of them have been arrested. "The police will soon arrest all of those found involved in this unfortunate incident," Mr. Dayal said.

The NCW said, "Any compromise on the dignity, safety, and privacy of women is unacceptable at any level." Its chairperson

Vijaya Rahatkar wrote to the Bihar DGP, directing him to immediately register an FIR over the incident. The NCW also directed that security, legal assistance, and psychological counselling be provided to the victims, and sought a detailed Action Taken Report in the matter. All necessary legal action should be taken to stop further sharing of the objectionable video being circulated on social media, it directed.

Bihar State Commission for Women Chairperson Apsara said, "I've spoken to the Jamui officials and they told me about the incident as it has happened on September 19 evening at 7 p.m. Stern action will be taken against all those found involved in this incident by people having a weird mindset."

The Bihar State Commission for Women stands with all such hapless wo-

men," Ms. Apsara added. "The video from Jamui is deeply disturbing," Mr. Gandhi said in a social media post. "Two class 10 students were stopped on a road. Harassed. Humiliated. Molested. A young girl's hands folded, begged to be let go while goons groped her and dragged her away. This is not 'culture'. It is patriarchy: the belief that any man can police a girl's body, her movement, her choice... When control is mistaken for culture, and such attitudes are normalised by 'Andhbhakt's', mobs start believing they are the law," he added.

'Why is a girl not safe?'
Demanding prosecution of the culprits under the POC- SO Act, Mr. Gandhi, who is the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, asked, "Who gave these men the right to behave like this? The Bihar government must answer why a girl is not safe on a public road at 7 p.m.?"

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge demanded the "harshest punishment for culprits, and accountability". Such incidents, he said, "scream to expose the lies and hypocrisy of the BJP's 'Nari Shakti Vandan' and 'Beti Bachao' schemes", meant to empower women.

Rashtriya Janata Dal

leader Tejashwi Yadav, Leader of Opposition in the Bihar Legislative Assembly, also slammed the State government in a social media post.

"Bihar has been shamed by the BJP-NDA government. Everyone is ashamed. On the Jamui incident, the government's people are making low-level statements... When the Jamui incident happened, [Bihar Chief Minister] Samrat Choudhary was holding a caste conference," he said.

Mr. Yadav's Singapore-based sister Rohini Acharya said: "The incident in Jamui is extremely shameful and expresses the dire state of law and order under the Samrat government, along with lax administrative influence and the stark reality of policing." She alleged that the "sisters and daughters of the State are entirely unsafe".

RJD leader and former MLA Shakti Singh Yadav said law and order had collapsed in the State.

State Rural Works Minister Sunil Kumar said he had spoken to the Jamui Superintendent of Police. "All those people allegedly involved into the incident would be behind bars very soon," said Mr. Kumar. (With inputs from Sreeparna Chakrabarty in New Delhi)

HC rejects plea over cash haul at former judge's house

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Monday declined to entertain a petition seeking registration of FIR and probe by a Special Investigation Team (SIT) or the CBI into the alleged discovery of a large quantity of cash following a fire at the residence of former Delhi High Court judge Yashwant Varma.

Justice Amit Bansal pointed out that the petitioner, advocate Ghanshyam Upadhyay, had other remedies available under law and asked why he had not approached the trial court seeking registration of FIR. "This is a wild witch hunt. You have nothing better to do?" the court remarked.

Mr. Upadhyay submitted that the circumstances surrounding the incident were "extraordinary" and argued that the lower court could not "do justice to the matter".

"This is regarding Justice Yashwant Varma. Criminal law can be set into motion by anyone. There is no embargo," he said.

When the court indicated that it was inclined to dismiss the petition, Mr. Upadhyay withdrew it, stating that he would pursue the remedies available in law. The petitioner had previously moved the Supreme Court with a similar plea, which was dismissed in August.

17-year-old Naga youth shot dead in Manipur

Press Trust of India
IMPHAL

A teen was shot dead by suspected militants in Manipur's Tamenglong district on Monday, police said.

The Naga youth, identified as N.K. Wiphenbou (17), was walking alone from Upper Nkou village to Tamei town when he was attacked around 10.30 a.m.

Naga village volunteers later found his body along a narrow path, they said.

Former Chief Minister N. Biren Singh condemned the killing and said, "Manipur cannot continue to lose innocent lives to this endless cycle of violence."

Senior Naga leader and Naga People's Front legislator Awangbou Newmai also condemned the killing, describing it as "cowardly" and "heinous acts of terrorism that target innocent civilians and threaten peace".

Raipur colleges told to shift all foreign students to hostels

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

The Chhattisgarh government on Monday instructed educational institutions in Raipur to relocate all foreign students currently residing in private rented accommodations to campus accommodation, and ensure they are aware of "local social norms" and "customs". The decision was taken after locals complained of indiscipline and unlawful activities by foreign students, according to a statement issued by the Raipur (Rural) Police.

The instructions were issued following a meeting between Raipur Collector Gaurav Kumar Singh, Superintendent of Police (Rural) Shweta Srivastava Sinha, and the Vice-Chancellors and representatives of various universities and educational institutions operating in Raipur district, the state-

ment added. "Universities and educational institutions were directed to ensure proper arrangements for the accommodation and transportation of foreign students. Instructions were issued to relocate foreign students currently residing outside university/college hostels – such as in private houses, PGs [paying guest facilities], or other locations – to secure hostels provided by or affiliated with the institution within the next 15 to 30 days," said a senior police officer.

The officer added that the administration and police had been receiving complaints from local citizens regarding foreign students from time to time. "Taking these complaints into account, institutions have been directed to ensure effective monitoring, counselling, and disciplinary mechanisms at their own level," the officer said.

Cause of concern



Back on shore: Ganesh idols washed ashore at the Palepalem Beach in Kothapatnam, near Ongole in Andhra Pradesh on Monday. A large number of idols were immersed in the sea by devotees from surrounding villages on Sunday. Immersion of idols made of non-biodegradable materials has sparked concern among environmentalists. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

Court orders fresh hearing in Sonia's voter roll entry case

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Monday allowed a revision plea challenging a September 11, 2025 Magistrate order refusing to probe into the allegation that Congress leader Sonia Gandhi's name was included in the electoral roll three years before she acquired Indian citizenship in 1983.

Special judge Vishal Gogne quashed the Magisterial Court's order as "non-speaking". The order had dismissed a complaint filed by advocate Vikas Tripathi, vice-president of the Central Delhi Court Bar Association of the Rouse Avenue courts.

"The impugned order suffers from a manifest error in law on account of non-compliance with Section 175(3) of Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), inter alia, not hearing the submissions of the



Sonia Gandhi

police officer concerned and non-calling of a status report from the police station concerned," the judge said.

He said the "non-speaking" nature of the order was evident as the Magistrate did not consider the twin options under law: directing registration of FIR or conducting proceedings under BNSS.

The court remanded the matter back to the Magistrate to pass a reasoned order after hearing fresh arguments. It posted the matter for further proceedings on September 29.

Aadhaar no proof of age for registration of marriage: Karnataka

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Department of Stamps and Registration in Karnataka has directed officials across the State to not consider Aadhaar card as proof of age for the bride and groom for registration of marriages.

In a circular, it said, "Officials must consider either birth certificate or school certificate and in the absence of these two documents, they can consider medical certificate issued

by doctor for registration of marriage." The direction came in the light of incidents where the age in the Aadhaar card and birth certificate were mismatched, resulting in child marriage.

Child rights activists across the State have alleged that parents or guardians of the bride changed the age in the Aadhaar card photocopy or through a correction window available under the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI)."

businessline's 8th Changemaker Awards to be given today

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The stage is set for the eighth edition of the *businessline* Changemaker Awards in New Delhi on Tuesday. The awards honour the country's quiet architects of societal transformation.

Union Minister for Finance and Corporate Affairs Nirmala Sitharaman will be the chief guest, marking her third time anchoring the marquee event in seven years.

The milestone edition is presented by Sastra Deemed University and powered by City Union Bank. The associate partners



are State Bank of India, Life Insurance Corporation of India, Government of Andhra Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh Industrial Infrastructure Corporation, Citizen Watches, Government of Uttarakhand, Jammu & Kashmir Bank, National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development, NTPC Ltd., Indian Bank, Steel

Authority of India Ltd., GAIL (India) Ltd., Essar Group, ICAFI Group, NMDCL Ltd. and UCO Bank. The mobility partner is Kia Sorento.

Award selection jury
Over 1,600 nominations across five categories were received for the awards, starting with a public call on May 12. Simultaneously, knowledge partners – Ashoka Foundation and Deloitte – and *businessline* journalists nominated potential candidates.

The submission window closed at midnight on July 7, and all entries underwent multiple screening rounds based on the selec-

tion criteria. The awards feature five categories: Social, Digital, and Financial Transformation, alongside Young Changemaker and Iconic Changemaker.

The flagship 'Changemaker of the Year' award honours far-reaching impact.

The *businessline* editorial team and knowledge partners select the Iconic Changemaker nominees.

The award selection jury met in Chennai on August 10.

Chaired by Justice (retired) Prabha Sridevan, the 2026 jury includes Suresh Narayanan, Safeena Husain, B. Santhanam, N.S. Nappinai, A. Balasubrama-

nian and Mukund Rajan.

Seven editions of the awards have been held since 2018, the year *The Hindu businessline* stepped into its 25th year of publishing. It could not be held in 2021 due to the pandemic.

After the nomination window closes, *businessline* and knowledge partners Deloitte and Ashoka screen and evaluate the applications. Niiti Consulting, the validation partner, then validates the shortest-listed nominees before an independent jury selects the winners.

In 2025, the DRDO won Changemaker of the Year, while the Azim Premji Foundation was named

Iconic Changemaker. Ara-ku Valley Coffee received the Financial Transformation award, and Bhashini won for Digital Transformation. Impulse NGO Network took home the Social Transformation honour. The Young Changemaker award was shared by Kalyani Shinde and the Young Tinker Foundation.

The awards for 2025 were given away by Hardeep Singh Puri, Union Minister of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

Scan the QR code to watch the award ceremony live on YouTube.



Namibian cheetah Gaurav died in Madhya Pradesh's Kuno National Park on Monday evening while undergoing treatment, an official said. Ten-year-old Gaurav was rescued from the wild on September 12 after he was observed to be weak and dull. The director said based on the preliminary clinical examination, an underlying chronic condition was suspected. "Despite continued treatment and supportive care, his condition deteriorated, and he died at around 4 p.m. on Monday," he said, adding that the exact cause of the death will be ascertained after post-mortem examination. Kuno National Park now has 51 cheetahs, the director said.

The Supreme Court on Monday sought a response from the States of Maharashtra and Haryana on a plea by stand-up comedian Pranit More to club FIRs registered against him in connection with the ‘₹370 biryani’ controversy. A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant also issued notice to the Union government. The Maharashtra Cyber Police had registered an FIR against Mr. More, the member of the audience, Himanshu Jangra, and another person under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. A separate petition had been filed by an advocate over Mr. More’s show which had been held in Gurugram.

Six persons have been arrested for molesting a woman doctor and assaulting her husband and other friends in a movie hall at Kolkata's Acropolis Mall on Sunday night. According to police, the couple went to watch a movie with their friends in the mall. Six men started intimidating her by making obscene gestures and derogatory comments. When her husband and friends protested, the accused assaulted them. A case under Sections 115(2) (voluntarily causing hurt), 79 (outraging woman's modesty), 126 (wrongful restraint) under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita have been booked against them.

Union Road Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari said on Monday the government will soon notify a policy rewarding safe driving with lower insurance premiums and penalising rash driving and traffic violations. "Good drivers should pay less for insurance; reckless drivers and rule-breakers should face penalties," he said. He said this would promote better road manners. The Minister had earlier said the government was planning a system to make drivers more accountable. Under the proposal, every traffic offence would lead to points being cut from a person's driving licence and vehicle registration. If too many points pile up, the licence or registration certificate could be suspended.

The law officer requested the CJI to constitute the Bench to facilitate the NHAI to make its request for a modification of the court's direction of November last year.

SUDOKU

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Sudoku

A logic puzzle game that involves filling a 9x9 grid with numbers so that each row, column, and 3x3 sub-grid contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

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Difficulty Rating: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle

G	V	A	R	A	E	G
A	S	T	F	R	E	T
L	T	I	F	R	E	T
P	O	L	I	G	E	T
L	S	A	F	E	S	T
L	E	A	P	E	R	E
G	A	S	H	E	R	E
A	N	S	I	T	L	
B	U	S	T	A	M	O
R	S	P	E	C		
A	U	T	H	O	R	E
A	A	A	U	R		
L	E	A	P	E	R	E
L	P	L	O	B	T	E
M	A	G	E	R	E	N

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

1	5	3	6	9	7	2	4	8
7	4	2	8	5	1	9	3	6
6	8	9	2	3	4	7	1	5
5	2	6	9	4	8	3	7	1
3	7	4	5	1	6	8	2	9
9	1	8	3	7	2	6	5	4
2	6	5	4	6	3	1	9	7
4	3	7	1	6	9	5	8	2
8	9	1	7	2	5	4	6	3

FAITH

Narada visits Valmiki

Valmiki Ramayana begins with Narada's visit to Valmiki's ashram. Narada was a distinguished sage and the son of Brahma. So, Valmiki asked him some questions. He listed 16 qualities and asked Narada who had all these qualities. But he laid down some conditions. The possessor of those qualities had to be alive at the time. He had to be living in bhuloka and he had to be a human being. The answer to Valmiki's question was obvious, because Lord Narayana had come to earth as a human being in the Rama avatara. Rama was in bhuloka at that time. Valmiki had Rama in mind when he put the question to Narada, said M.A. Venkatakrishnan in a discourse. Although he knew about Rama, he wanted to hear Narada talking about Him.

Instead of asking Narada directly to tell him about Rama, Valmiki asked him indirectly. When did this visit of Narada to Valmiki's ashram take place? It was when Rama was king of Ayodhya and Sita too was still there, not yet having been banished. Rama must have been between 40 and 45 years of age at that time. From the Valmiki Ramayana, we can infer that Rama was 12 when He married Sita. She must have been about six then. They were happily together in Ayodhya for 12 years. Rama had completed 24 years and was entering His 25th year, when He was banished. He spent 14 years in the forest. So, He must have been 39 when He returned. His coronation took place after His return to Ayodhya.

Narada met Valmiki in the latter's ashram on the banks of the Tamasa river. This place is near Kanpur, in Uttar Pradesh. But before Valmiki moved here, he had his ashram in Chitrakuta.

Why scientists are rethinking the chemical ‘arms race’ against fungi

New research is showing that fungi are protected from antifungals by genetic mutations as well as by making more copies of protective genes, and it seems the idea of dousing fungal pathogens with antifungals is nearing its end; the next-generation of antifungals will need more planning

Somdatta Karak
HYDERABAD

For a long time, fungal infections have meant itchy skin, discoloured nails and sometimes hair loss.

These symptoms are collectively called dermatophytosis and are caused by a group of fungi called dermatophytes.

“Unfortunately, immunocompromised patients can get lesions all over their body. The itchiness and the lesions can get so severe that people even get suicidal thoughts,” said Shivaprakash Rudramurthy, Professor of medical mycology at the Postgraduate Institute of Medical Education and Research (PGIMER), Chandigarh.

Global warming

Dermatophytes are molds: fungi that grow in long strands. The other common category of fungi is yeast, which are single, oval-shaped cells. Among the yeasts, *Candida auris* is rapidly emerging as a multidrug resistant pathogen in ICU facilities. It enters the blood stream and causes severe infections, most of which are untreatable by the available antifungals. According to Professor Rudramurthy, those infected suffer a 30%-40% mortality rate.

C. auris has become a menace only in the last two decades. The first report was in 2009 in Japan. Several other fungal species have become more pathogenic only in recent times. The cause of this rise remains unresolved but scientists and medical doctors have some ideas.

Fungi grow best in damp places below 30 degrees Celsius, so they can grow on our skin, especially in moist areas of the body, like armpits and the genital area. However, bloodstream infections in humans were rare because they could not survive in the body’s 37 degrees Celsius temperature.

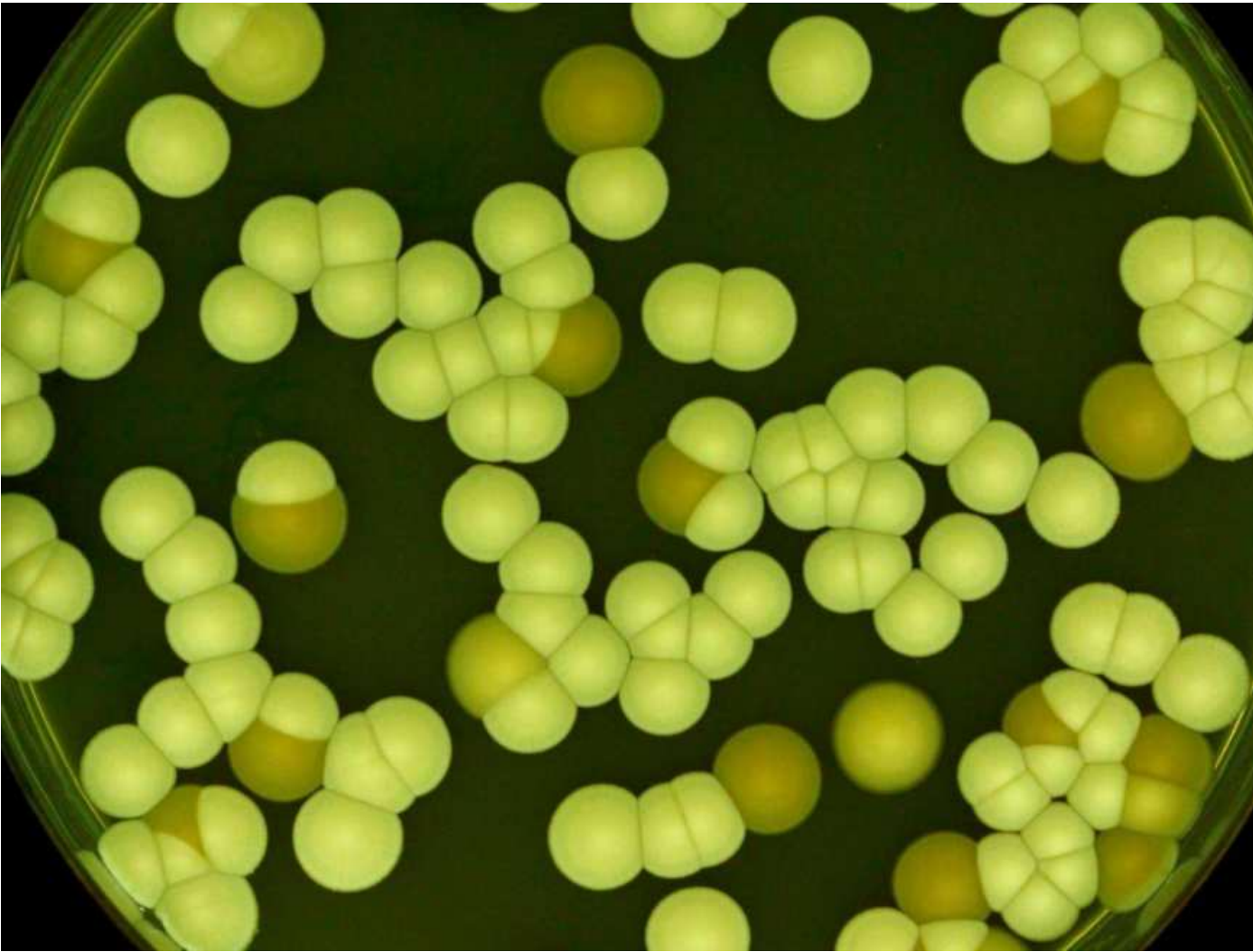
“Fungal infections are common in cold-blooded animals with lower body temperatures,” Sriram Varahan, a mycologist at CSIR-Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology, Hyderabad, said.

“But global warming puts a selective pressure on fungi such that only the more heat-tolerant ones survive. These ones can survive inside our bodies too, if they gain access to it. This is called the fungal infection – mammalian selection hypothesis.”

Clinical samples

Today, roughly 20% of infections reported in hospitals are fungal in nature – yet most hospitals in India lack the capabilities and infrastructure to identify fungal pathogens, Professor Rudramurthy said. This prompted the PGIMER to begin storing fungal pathogens some 25 years ago. Today, the institute holds a stock of 15,000 clinical fungal isolates across India and helps other medical centres and clinicians identify and culture them for study, free of cost.

The *C. auris* isolates from the PGIMER’s repository have come handy for Kaustuv Sanyal and his research associate Aswathy Narayanan, both at the Jawaharlal Nehru Centre for Advanced Scientific Research, Bengaluru. They study how fungal pathogens divide and their genomes evolve.



Candida auris growing in a nutrient-rich growth medium. The fungus has become a menace in the last two decades. PHANCANHTRINH (CC BY)

In a recent study published in *Nature Communications*, they characterised the clinical isolates of *C. auris* found across India. Their focus was the pathogen’s ability to resist antifungals. They were able to establish their findings in patient samples and go beyond earlier studies in model systems.

“More than 90% clinical isolates of *C. auris* are resistant to common azole-based antifungals, such as fluconazole,” Professor Sanyal said. Some “30% of them are resistant to another class of antifungals called the polyenes. They mostly respond to a different class of antifungals called the echinocandins.”

A drug may not work on a pathogen for many reasons, including the drug’s target becoming mutated or the drug’s effect being negated by the pathogen’s own biomolecules. Dr. Narayanan and her collaborators at the Indian Institute of Science Education and Research, Thiruvananthapuram, found significant changes in drug-resistant *C. auris* genomes that could explain why Indian clinical isolates were able to resist azoles and echinocandins.

Susceptibility tests

A fungal cell has two protective layers surrounding it. The outermost is the cell wall and the inner one is the cell membrane. Azole and polyene antifungals target a fat called ergosterol that is enriched in the cell membrane. Echinocandins target the cell wall.

“When we grow *C. auris* isolates in the presence of fluconazole, the pathogen fights back by making extra copies of the *Erg 11* gene. This in turn helps in higher production of ergosterol, thereby

eliminating the effect of the azole drug,” Dr Narayanan said. The study found parts in the *C. auris* genome where additional copies of the *Erg11* gene were present.

With echinocandin drugs such as caspofungin, the team found mutations in the *Fks1* gene that allowed the pathogen to resist the drug’s action. The team also found genetic changes promoting higher tolerance of echinocandins.

“*Fks1* mutations can enable *C. auris* to survive even caspofungin doses up to 16 ug/ml. That means a patient with such a pathogen will need the drug at a concentration higher than 16 µg/ml,” Professor Sanyal said.

“Today, clinicians would not know that because they test the pathogen’s ability to survive only until 2 µg/mL of caspofungin – as defined by the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, and followed globally.”

The logical thing for clinicians would be to look for mutations like in the *Fks1* gene and decide the limits for tests to decide the antifungal dose for patients. But due to associated costs, a more practical way is to increase the limits of susceptibility tests for caspofungin to higher than 16 ug/ml, Professor Sanyal added.

C. auris, without any specific gene mutation or gene duplication, still responds to high concentrations of caspofungin in unexpected ways. While the pathogen dies at lower concentrations of the drug, at exceptionally high ones, it survives. This is paradoxical.

“This is because caspofungin at high doses activates compensatory pathways in the fungus,” Professor Sanyal explained. “The fungus starts producing

chitin, the raw material of the fungal cell wall, in large quantities. Any damage that caspofungin brings about on the cell wall is compensated by the extra chitin production. And thus the cell wall remains intact despite the antifungal.”

Such examples of paradoxical growth are called the Eagle effect, named for the U.S. pathologist Harry Eagle.

Beyond the arms race

The studies underline the importance of clinicians conducting more nuanced susceptibility tests to decide the antifungal doses. They show that fungi are protected from antifungals by genetic mutations as well as by making more copies of protective genes.

Professor Sanyal also stressed on the need for a combination of therapies to target cellular compensatory pathways, keeping the major antifungals effective against drug-tolerant species.

However, Dr. Varahan said he believed scientists and doctors need to think of gentler alternatives: “When we target [a molecule] without which an organism cannot live at all, evolution ensures that its population survives with a changed molecule. So instead of participating in an arms race, it is perhaps better to target the less critical molecular pathways, inhibition of which will allow the pathogen to still survive but not cause a disease.” It seems the idea of dousing fungal pathogens with antifungals is nearing its end. The next-generation of antifungals will need more planning.

(Somdatta Karak heads science communication at CSIR-CCMB. somdattakararak@cmb.res.in)



The Tilcayo measures about 46 cm long and weighs around 1.4 kg, making it smaller than the average domestic cat. REUTERS

Cat family gets a new Bolivian member after over a century

Reuters

A diminutive wild cat that inhabits Bolivia’s cloud forest has been identified as a previously unknown species, marking the first time a new living cat species has been formally named and described in more than a century.

The cat, called Tilcayo by local communities, is part of a group called tiger cats found across much of South America. It was found in Bolivia’s lush Yungas forest, a mountainous region where forests are often covered by clouds and surrounded by high humidity, according to researchers. It measures about 46 cm long and weighs around 1.4 kg, making it smaller than the average domestic cat.

Researchers used genetic data to confirm that the cat is a new species, and gave it the scientific name *Leopardus tilcayo*, retaining its local name. “Its fur is light brown ... with irregularly shaped rosettes across its body,” said Paola Nogales-Ascarrunz, a National Geographic explorer and one of the authors of the study describing the newly identified

Researchers used genetic data to confirm that the cat is a new species, and gave it the scientific name *Leopardus tilcayo*

species published on September 17 in the journal *Current Biology*. Little is yet known about the cat’s biology and lifestyle. Remains of small rodents in scat samples suggest they may form part of its diet, while camera-trap evidence indicates it could be more active at night, Ms. Nogales-Ascarrunz said.

Tiger cats are so-called cryptic species, meaning they cannot easily be distinguished merely by appearance, said evolutionary biologist and study co-lead author Jonas Lescroart of the University of Antwerp in Belgium. Tiger cats previously had been considered a single species, but genetic studies decades ago suggested the existence of multiple species. Referring to the new species, Mr. Lescroart said, “Our information at this moment is limited to the two live individuals that we examined, and a small number of camera-trap records.”

One of the live cats is a 10-year-old male that now lives in Senda Verde Wildlife Sanctuary after being kept by a local family in their home. Observing the Bolivian cat drew interest because “its characteristics did not match the descriptions, most of them based on Brazilian cats,” Ms. Nogales-Ascarrunz said. “This made us wonder: what tiger cat do we actually have in Bolivia?”

The team analysed DNA from 38 cats sampled across several South American countries, including eight museum specimens. The study found that tiger cats are in fact five genetically distinct species.

“We never expected this Bolivian tiger cat to be a separate species, and no one had ever proposed it as a different animal, subspecies or otherwise,” Mr. Lescroart said. Genetic analysis suggested that the Tilcayo lineage separated from other tiger cats about 1.4 million years ago. “The more differences in their DNA, the longer the time that we estimate those lineages to have been physically separated,” Mr. Lescroart said, adding that such a gap is generally considered a species-level divide in cats.

The research team also described a new tiger cat subspecies in Peru’s Yungas, naming it *Leopardus tigrinus antisyayo* after Antisyayo, the region of the old Inca Empire that included the area it inhabits.

The International Union for Conservation of Nature, or IUCN, Red List tracking the status of species currently treats tiger cats as two “vulnerable” species with declining populations.

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Vivid displays in the wild

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

The X is the only mammal covered in true scales, which are made of keratin — the same material in your fingernails. Other such mammals are mainly covered in hair or fur; some also have quills and spikes. Name X, which also curls into a ball when threatened, turning its overlapping scales into a tough shield.

QUESTION #2

The fur of sloths often has a greenish tinge because it hosts ____, with the tinge allowing these arboreal animals to blend in with the canopy as camouflage. In addition, sloth hair also has grooves to trap moisture and which support a small ecosystem of moths and beetles. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION #3

Sometimes called the ‘stinkbird’, the

Y has a spiky crest. Y chicks also have wing claws that allow it to climb trees. And unlike most birds, the Y ferments leaves in its foregut, like a cow, in order to break down the organic matter and extract otherwise inaccessible nutrients. Name Y, which is the national bird of Guyana.

QUESTION #4

A close relative of seahorses, the ____ has elaborate, leaf-like appendages that make spotting the animal very difficult among seaweed. It also swims slowly using small, nearly transparent fins. The males carry fertilised eggs on the underside of their tails until the young hatch. Fill in the blanks.

QUESTION #5

Name the musk ox’s exceptionally soft, fine underwool that sheds naturally each spring. The material manages to insulate the ox against the Arctic cold, is warmer than sheep’s wool, and is thus highly prized for lightweight textiles.



Visual: Name this bird, whose males sport elaborate, lyre-shaped plumes for tail feathers. The bird is also famous for mimicking a variety of sounds, from the songs of other birds to chainsaws. FIR0002 (CC BY-NC)

Please send in your answers to
science@thehindu.co.in

Answers to September 17 quiz:

- Paradox over how much people are prepared to gamble – **Ans: St. Petersburg**
 - Game involving stacking discs of various sizes on three towers – **Ans: Tower of Hanoi**
 - Economist who used NYC to illustrate effect of shared expectations – **Ans: Thomas Schelling**
 - Solid geometry problem involving cutting windows in a hemisphere – **Ans: Florentine**
 - Birthplace of Apollo in Greek mythology – **Ans: Delos**
- Visual: **Königsberg**

First contact:

Prem Raj P. | K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Sudhir Thapa | Prem Nath Tiwari

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to
science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



Presumed ineligible

The ECI must end its method of deleting first and verifying later

Not one eligible elector should be left out of the electoral rolls. This statement appears in nearly every document released by the Election Commission of India (ECI) as part of the ongoing SIR process, and the Supreme Court of India, which is hearing petitions challenging the SIR, has also used this refrain. Yet, according to an ECI counter-affidavit filed in the Court, by early September 2026, out of more than 38 lakh appeals submitted to SIR appellate tribunals in West Bengal, just over 1,22,000 appeals were disposed of (a disposal rate of just 3.2%) and 1,13,943 electors were added back to the rolls (an inclusion rate of nearly 93%). This suggests that the claims/corrections phase in the West Bengal SIR – during which judicial officers deployed for verification deemed 27 lakh of the 60 lakh electors flagged for “logical discrepancies” to be ineligible – was deeply flawed. More than 22 lakh of those found ineligible have since appealed, and ECI data show that more than nine in 10 cases decided by the tribunals have ended with the electors back on the rolls. If these “inclusion” and “disposal” rates hold, the majority of the 27 lakh electors should not have been ineligible in the first place and are now struggling to get back on the rolls – an indication that massive disenfranchisement preceded the West Bengal Assembly polls. With municipal elections in the State approaching, the ECI must speed up the appellate process and restore eligible electors to the rolls.

In Phase 3 of the SIR, *The Hindu's* analysis found that in 24 out of Delhi's 70 constituencies, the draft roll now records fewer electors than those who voted in the February 2025 Assembly election. Such large-scale deletion cannot hold unless there was a major migration process in the capital region or large numbers of voters were never ordinarily resident in Delhi. A more plausible answer is that the enumeration itself has struck off actual voters. The process puts the onus of proving eligibility on the elector, and the ECI's dropping of enumeration forms at homes has not translated into full enumeration. Requiring electors to link themselves to rolls drawn in the early 2000s then manufactures “discrepancies” even when documents are valid. In Delhi, this “mapping” has put 13.79 lakh electors under notice with a further 19.33 lakh flagged for “logical discrepancies” on undefined grounds. While hearing the Bihar SIR petitions, the Court had intervened sharply to stop eligible voters from being struck off. Its permissiveness in the year since, towards an insouciant ECI has allowed disenfranchisement on a scale that will remain a black mark on the jurisprudence of universal adult franchise in India. As the Court hears petitions on Delhi and West Bengal, it must compel the ECI to reverse course.

Unsafe space

Deployment of weapons calls for multilateral governance in space

Although the U.S. military doctrine was openly considering offensive and defensive space control by 2025, the admission on September 14 by U.S. Air Force Secretary Troy Meink, and confirmed by Space Force chief Gen. Douglas Schiess, that the country has deployed “on-orbit space control weapons” to “defend against hostile adversary action” is cause for concern. Satellite systems increasingly underpin communications, energy, and financial networks and many commercial systems serve civilian and military users. To that end, the U.S., Russia, China, and India, among others, have been developing counter-space capabilities while contributing to the technological and strategic environment rendering earth orbit the next major battlefield. The increasing military use of commercial satellites can endanger the protections they enjoy under international humanitarian law even as this law is underprepared for satellites being highly interconnected and often dual-use. That said, the details that justify the need for orbital defence systems also make poorly specified weapons a potential cause of instability. Mr. Meink described the weapon as defensive, but U.S. military doctrine defines “space control” as encompassing both offensive and defensive operations.

Compounding the consequences of confusion when two steerable satellites approach each other without understanding the other's intentions – including due to future autonomous satellites running artificial intelligence models onboard – is the lack of policy details. What constitutes “hostile action” and what the weapon can do remain unclear. While the Outer Space Treaty does not ban weapons in orbit *per se*, Article IV prohibits nuclear weapons or other weapons of mass destruction in orbit – a fluid line considering the centrality of satellite-based networks for contemporary society and the ability of conventional weapons to render damage en masse; its Article III also requires space activities to comply with international law. But when an autonomous, dual-use orbital asset operated by a commercial entity initiates an unwanted defensive strike, the existing rules, including the Liability Convention, cannot be applied straightforwardly to determine accountability. The rules have become too coarse for what contemporary technologies, and the declining esteem for a rules-based world order, warrant. The U.N. Open-Ended Working Group on the ‘Prevention of an Arms Race in Outer Space’ should offer governments an opportunity to address the disclosure. The U.S. government should also reveal the particulars of the weapons it has deployed, and enter into a multilateral governance arrangement that defines exact thresholds of action and escalation.

At the NITI Aayog meeting on June 11, 2026, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay announced the goal of transforming Tamil Nadu into a \$1.5 trillion economy by 2035-36. A similar view has also been expressed by others.

Required growth rate

Tamil Nadu's Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) was ₹35.29 lakh crore in 2025-26. To achieve the target of \$1.5 trillion in 10 years, Tamil Nadu would have to increase the size of its economy to ₹172.56 lakh crore by 2035-36, registering a 4.9-fold increase. This calculation is based on the assumption that the exchange rate of one dollar in terms of rupees will appreciate by 2% per annum from its present level, touching ₹115.38 per dollar in 2035-36. This implies that achieving the target would require a nominal growth rate of 17.2% and, assuming inflation of 5%, a real growth rate of 12.2% per annum continuously for 10 years.

If the Tamil Nadu economy grows at a nominal rate of 17.2%, the State's per capita income will increase from \$4,808 in 2025-26 to \$19,157 in 2035-36, which would be slightly higher than the \$16,383 estimated by the writers as per capita income norm for a developed country. This estimation is made based on the past trends in the cut off set by the World Bank. In this scenario, Tamil Nadu, with a per capita



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The State's growth path will determine when it reaches its \$1.5 trillion ambition

income of \$16,672, would achieve Viksit Bharat status by 2034-35, well before India's aspiration to become a developed country by 2047. However, this may not be within the realm of possibility. In the past, Tamil Nadu's real growth exceeded 12% only in three years: 13.96% in 2005-06, 15.21% in 2006-07 and 13.12% in 2010-11. It must also be noted that the growth rate required to achieve the target would rise if the rupee depreciates more than what is implied in the above calculations. Also if the cut off per capita norm for developed country is higher than what we have estimated, it will again take a longer time to reach the target.

Possible scenarios

The *table* below presents the results for a scenario with a 15% nominal growth rate, which may be considered achievable given the required effort. Under this scenario, the target would be achieved in 2037-38. Assuming 5% inflation, the real growth rate required would be 10%.

Under this possible scenario, the State's per capita income in 2035-36 will be \$15,850, which will be slightly lower than the \$16,383 cut-off for a developed country. However, under this scenario, Tamil Nadu will achieve developed-country status in 2036-37, as its per capita income of \$17,850 will be higher than the \$16,565 cut-off for that year.

The feasibility of achieving this real growth rate depends on the past performance of the Tamil Nadu economy. From 2005-06 to 2011-12,

Estimated per capita income and other related indicators till 2037-38

Year	Nominal growth (%)*	Nominal GSDP (₹ trillion)	Exchange rate (₹/U.S.\$)	Nominal GSDP (U.S. \$ trillion)	Per Capita Income (PCI) in U.S. \$	World Bank's PCI norm for developed country (U.S. \$) (estimated)
2025-26	15	35.3	94.65	0.37	4,808	14,558
2026-27	15	40.6	96.55	0.42	5,413	14,740
2027-28	15	46.7	98.48	0.47	6,095	14,923
2028-29	15	53.7	100.45	0.53	6,862	15,105
2029-30	15	61.7	102.46	0.60	7,726	15,288
2030-31	15	71	104.51	0.68	8,699	15,470
2031-32	15	81.6	106.60	0.77	9,808	15,653
2032-33	15	93.9	108.73	0.86	11,058	15,835
2033-34	15	108	110.90	0.97	12,468	16,018
2034-35	15	124.1	113.12	1.10	14,058	16,200
2035-36	15	142.8	115.38	1.24	15,850	16,383
2036-37	15	164.2	117.69	1.40	17,850	16,565
2037-38	15	188.8	120.04	1.57	20,120	16,748

* Required Real Growth = 15%-5%=10%

A Malacca-Singapore model for resolving Hormuz

As the siege warfare continues in the Strait of Hormuz and the world suffers, it may be instructive to revisit the Straits of Malacca and Singapore.

The Strait of Malacca runs for some 800 kilometres between the Malay Peninsula and the Indonesian island of Sumatra, connecting the Andaman Sea to the Strait of Singapore, while the Strait of Singapore, some 105 km long, forms its eastern continuation and connects the Malacca Strait to the South China Sea.

A territorial turning point

The Straits were once considered “international” in the sense that they were like the high seas, over which no country had any claim. In 1971, Malaysia, Indonesia and Singapore jointly challenged this notion.

Indonesia, a newly decolonised nation, feared for the security of its individual islands if the waters between them were not considered its territory, and in 1957 declared that all waters “surrounding, between and connecting the islands” were Indonesian waters. Then Indonesian President Sukarno had an adversarial relationship with the colonial powers, and the nation was wary of big-power interference.

As the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) was being formulated, Indonesia insisted that its territorial waters should extend 12 nautical miles from the outermost islands. Malaysia, despite its 1963 armed conflict with Indonesia over Borneo, revised the stance it had taken at the 1958 UNCLOS conference and also announced a 12-nautical-mile territorial sea, choosing to work with Jakarta on the Straits through bilateral treaties and joint naval patrols. The two nations continue to cooperate actively to this day.

At their narrowest points, the Straits are well under 24 nautical miles wide. Once both states claimed 12-nautical-mile territorial seas, the zones met in the middle, leaving no strip of high seas or exclusive economic zone (EEZ) between them. Under the customary law of the time, this meant that the Straits were simply territorial seas, where foreign vessels enjoyed only the right of “innocent passage” – a right that Indonesia or Malaysia could suspend for security reasons and



M. Kalyanaraman

The Malacca-Singapore experience has lessons for navigating the Hormuz impasse

that excluded submerged submarines.

The three nations issued a joint statement in 1971 proposing a coordinating body comprising representatives of the three states to administer the Straits. Singapore, an island nation dependent on trade and shipping, did not quite agree to declaring the Straits “not international”, but did make common cause with Malaysia over the safety of navigation.

The Straits and the great powers

Japan, a major player through the Japan-funded Malacca Strait Council, offered cooperation with the three states rather than seeking an internationalised regime. The United States and the Soviet Union, otherwise rivals, were allies on this one issue – keeping the Straits under territorial waters “international” so that ships retained the right of “continued, politically uncluttered transit”.

As UNCLOS entered its final phase of formulation in the 1970s, the United Kingdom introduced the concept of “transit passage” for straits connecting the high seas or EEZs – a right of transit only in a “continuous and expeditious” manner, with no stopping or loitering, but one that applied to warships as well, going beyond mere innocent passage. Indonesia agreed to this formulation with reservations, trading its acceptance for greater security for its archipelago, which UNCLOS eventually addressed separately. Malaysia's concerns centred on environmental safety, insurance requirements and permissible vessel draught.

In 2007, the three states working with the international community arrived at a Cooperative Mechanism building on a traffic separation scheme similar to what Iran and Oman had agreed for the Strait of Hormuz in the 1960s. A core aspect of the 2007 mechanism was for user states and industry to contribute to a fund for aids to navigation, hydrographic surveys and safety projects, administered jointly with the littoral states.

The Aids to Navigation Fund is supported through voluntary financial contributions from non-profit organisations such as The Nippon Foundation and the International Foundation for Aids to Navigation, as well as industry

Tamil Nadu registered strong real growth, at 2004-05 prices, of 10.3% per annum, compared with an all-India growth rate of 8.2%. However, its average annual growth rate, at 2011-12 prices, declined to 6.98%, compared with an all-India growth of 6.96%, from 2012-13 to 2018-19. Interestingly, its growth performance improved to 9.1% from 2021-22 to 2025-26, compared with an all-India growth rate of 8.1%.

With an average real growth rate of 9.1% (and a nominal growth rate of 14.1%), Tamil Nadu's target will be achieved in 2038-39. Under this scenario, the developed-country per capita income norm will be attained in 2037-38. This should also be considered a possible scenario.

One trillion dollar economy

The earlier aspiration for Tamil Nadu was to reach a one-trillion-dollar economy by 2030. Under the 12.2% real growth scenario, the \$1 trillion economy target would be achieved in 2033-34. The target would be reached in 2034-35 under both the 10% and 9.1% growth scenarios.

To sustain a real growth rate of 10%, the investment rate required would be 40% of GSDP, assuming an Incremental Capital Output Ratio (ICOR) of 4. Achieving an ICOR of 4 itself would require improved efficiency in the use of capital. This investment would have to be financed by domestic savings, supplemented by a flow of resources from the rest of India and other countries. Tamil Nadu must be made an attractive investment destination by creating an appropriate investment environment.

Moreover, a stable economic environment, ensuring both price and fiscal stability, will support strong growth over a sustained period. With nominal growth of 14%, the State should work towards a fiscal deficit of less than 3% so that the debt-GSDP ratio stabilises at around 23%, a sustainable level in the medium term.

What has been presented so far can be described as the arithmetic of achieving a \$1.5 trillion economy by Tamil Nadu. What can happen a decade from now will depend on a number of factors.

Therefore, any projection over such a long period has to be conditional. Perhaps, the most likely scenario is a nominal growth rate of 14% per annum over the next 10 years, which will take Tamil Nadu towards becoming a \$1.5 trillion economy by 2038-39. We can always strive for something better.

stakeholders and states with an interest in the safe and efficient use of the Straits. These contributions do not amount to tolls. The fund is administered on a rotation basis by a committee comprising representatives of the three littoral States and the contributors. The three littoral States – Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore – do not impose fees, tolls or any other form of payment on ships exercising their right of transit passage.

The geographic parallel

The Strait of Hormuz is similar to the Malacca-Singapore Straits, in that the territorial waters of Iran and Oman intersect, making sections of the Strait part of their territorial waters.

In 1993, Iran, which has not ratified UNCLOS, passed a law requiring foreign warships to seek its authorisation to pass through the Strait. This continues to be a sore point today.

Persian Gulf nations have a history of both conflict and cooperation. The United Arab Emirates, for instance, was among Iran's leading trading partners. Qatar is among the Persian Gulf nations that have supported the Iran-Oman talks. It had also mooted the Malacca-Singapore straits as a model.

Yet, even if the Gulf nations arrive at a framework they all agree on, the U.S. has shown that it may not accept it. The Malacca-Singapore issue was resolved as UNCLOS itself was being put into effect, when trade-offs were part of negotiating a convention intended to govern the world's oceans.

A key concern in the Malacca-Singapore Straits was the safety of navigation and the environment, whereas in the Strait of Hormuz, the key issue is Iran's security.

Iran is demanding that all nations revisit the Strait of Hormuz, and some are willing to do so. Though Iran and Oman have apparently agreed on a framework for reopening the Strait of Hormuz, the Strait has not been reopened, and the U.S. has not accepted the arrangement. The context has changed, even though there are clear parallels in the technical details.

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A tussle that distresses

The challenge to the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as Chairman of Tata Sons on September 17 is distressing to the company's stakeholders in particular and to thousands of shareholders in the Indian corporate world in general (Page 1, “Tata Sons Board did not meet conditions: Trusts”, September 21). The reputation and esteem meticulously built over

many decades by the Tata brand in the business world are at great risk of erosion because of the impatient and intolerant attitude of the Board of Directors. A quarrel in public is no way to resolve differences among learned, experienced and wise board members. India, known for a paucity of eminent leaders in politics, eagerly looks to the corporate world for wise and pragmatic business leaders who can

provide good governance. Individual egos need to be set aside.

M.V. Nagavender Rao,
Hyderabad

Politics and decorum

Even the staunchest critics of Prime Minister Narendra Modi would find it difficult to accept Rahul Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, turning an event meant to address the serious issues confronting today's youth into a vehicle

to lampoon the Prime Minister. Using a stand-up comedian to mimic and ridicule Mr. Modi at such an event was unbecoming of the office of the Leader of the Opposition. By encouraging such mimicry, Mr. Gandhi has betrayed a lack of political maturity. A person portrayed by Gandhi family loyalists as a potential Prime Minister is expected to conduct himself with dignity and poise. The Bharatiya Janata Party's

outrage is not misplaced. S.K. Choudhury,
Bengaluru

The developments remind me of the days when Jawaharlal Nehru was Prime Minister. The celebrated cartoonist K. Shankar often drew cartoons criticising and poking fun at Nehru. Far from taking offence, Nehru reportedly encouraged Shankar to continue criticising him through his

cartoons. Whether one agrees with the criticism or not, this reflects an important democratic principle: those in power must be able to tolerate criticism, satire and even ridicule. Freedom of expression is one of the very foundations of a democratic society.

Mohan Nedungadi,
Cherppulassery, Keralam

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The Koran and politics of purdah

Recently, Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker Musliar of the Samastha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama issued a circular directing public halls and madrasas not to permit women to share public spaces with unrelated men during religious events.

He subsequently sought to justify the restriction with the startling claim that bringing women onto public platforms would cause “great destruction.” He attributed this danger to the mixing of men and women and said that the Koran itself requires women to remain confined to their homes, and prohibits them from appearing in public.

But the Koran does not instruct women to remain confined to their homes. It is conservative clerics who have historically sought to impose such restrictions by taking out of context the instruction in verse 33:33 to “stay in your houses” and “do not display yourselves as was the display of the former times of ignorance.”

Yet the verse occurs within a passage beginning at verse 28 that is explicitly addressed to the Prophet’s wives wherein the Prophet is instructed to give them a choice: they may seek the comforts and adornments of worldly life, in which case they will be granted a gracious separation, or they may choose Allah, the Prophet and the hereafter, for which they will receive a great reward. Their position is then distinguished from that of other women before laying down a heightened standard of conduct for them. They are told to avoid overly soft speech with men, to remain in their houses, not to display themselves as women did in the



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The historical record does not support the idea that Islam required women to be confined to their homes or excluded from public life

pre-Islamic period, and to follow Allah and the Prophet. The passage culminates in a reference intended to keep the Prophet’s household spiritually pure.

Not about all women

As is clear, the command to “remain in your houses” is addressed only to the Prophet’s wives. To remove this instruction from its specific context and present it as a universal Koranic command requiring all Muslim women to remain at home is to extend the verse beyond the scope stated in the passage itself.

Moreover, the historical record does not support the idea that Islam required women to be confined to their homes or excluded from public life. Hazrat Khadija, the Prophet’s first wife, was a successful merchant who conducted her own commercial affairs, and the Prophet himself worked for her as a trading agent before their marriage. Even after he became the Prophet, there is no indication that he asked Khadija to abandon her public life. Obviously, the Prophet did not regard a woman’s participation in economic and social life as incompatible with Islam.

The same is true of the Prophet’s wives who lived after the revelation of Koran 33:33. Hazrat Aisha travelled with the Prophet, including on military expeditions and for the Hajj, and later became one of the most important authorities on religion in the early Muslim community. She also played a public role in the political conflict that culminated in the Battle of the Camel in 656 CE. Hazrat Umm Salama, another wife of the Prophet, was likewise consulted on public matters.

These examples make it difficult to interpret “remain in your houses” in 33:33 as a command of absolute physical confinement. Whatever restrictions it imposed on the Prophet’s wives, the historical record provides little basis for turning it into a universal prohibition against women participating in public life or sharing public spaces with men. Not surprisingly, in *Al-Muhaddithat*, the English introduction to his 43-volume Arabic compendium of Muslim women scholars, Mohammad Akram Nadwi rejects the view that Islam is “a human construct, done mainly by men and therefore done to secure advantages for them at the expense of women.”

Nonetheless, the subjugation of women cannot be challenged through reformist rhetoric alone. It requires the Muslim laity to publicly question clerical authority itself, and political leaders to stop lending legitimacy to regressive clerical institutions through high-profile visits and public engagement. The recent meeting of Malaysian PM Anwar Ibrahim with Mr. Aboobacker in Keralam illustrates the problem. Such public recognition can embolden male clerics to present patriarchal interpretations as divine commands and discourage Muslims from questioning them. The future of Islam cannot be left to those who claim a monopoly over its interpretation. If Muslims are to progress, the Koran must remain the primary point of reference, while the Prophet’s life must be taken seriously as evidence of how Koranic principles were actually lived.

Persistent antagonism towards Urdu

In June 2026, a group of approximately 10-15 men entered Bharat Chandra High School in Armoor, Nizamabad district, Telangana, and allegedly manhandled its 37-year-old Principal, Aamir Khan. The incident reportedly arose from the perception that Urdu was being taught at the school. However, Mr. Khan, an English teacher, was not responsible for teaching Urdu; the subject had been taught briefly by another teacher. The school’s management board, headed by a person of Hindu background, had decided to introduce Urdu as a second language following a request from the parents of Muslim students, who constitute approximately 25% of the school’s total strength.

This episode is particularly significant in light of a Supreme Court judgment in April 2025, which described Urdu as a fine expression of *Ganga-Jamuni Tehzeeb*. A Bench comprising Justices Sudhanshu Dhulia and Vinod Chandran observed that “language belongs to a community, to a region, to people but not a religion.” The Court upheld the use of Urdu on the signboard of a municipal council in Maharashtra and declined to interfere with the Bombay High Court’s ruling, which had found no legal prohibition under the Maharashtra Local Authorities (Official Languages) Act, 2022, against the use of Urdu.

The contrast between the constitutional-legal recognition of Urdu as a linguistic and cultural tradition and the hostility towards it highlights the contested and communal



Shaikh Mujibur Rehman

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The antagonism towards Urdu is rooted in the perception that it is exclusively a language for Muslims

nature of the language in today’s India.

The antagonism towards Urdu is rooted in the perception that it is exclusively a language for Muslims. The establishment of Bangladesh in 1971 around the Bengali language demonstrated that Urdu is not the language of Muslims as a whole. Moreover, Urdu has historically been spoken and cultivated by Hindus, Sikhs, and others. Rakhshanda Jalil’s edited volume, *Whose Urdu Is It Anyway?*, brings together writings by several prominent non-Muslim literary figures, including Gulzar, Ramanand Sagar, Rajinder Singh Bedi, and Kishan Chander. Their contributions demonstrate how Urdu has historically been embedded within a diverse literary and cultural tradition. A particularly revealing case is that of Rahi Masoom Raza, the author associated with the TV serial *Mahabharat*. It has recently come to light that his novel *Aadha Gaon* (Half Village), a classic of modern Hindi literature, was originally written by him in Urdu.

Not all that different

In ordinary discourse, the difference between Hindi and Urdu is not easily noticeable. According to Paul Brass, Urdu, “in its original form, was nothing more grammatically than the spoken Hindustani of north India, particularly Khari Boli of the Delhi area, with an infusion of Persian, Arabic, and Turkish vocabulary.” This shared linguistic heritage highlights the extent to which Hindi and Urdu evolved from a common linguistic base. In 1837, Persian was replaced by English and other vernacular languages in various

provinces of British India for administrative and judicial purposes. In north India, however, the vernacular language selected for official use was not Hindi, but Urdu written in the Perso-Arabic script. This linguistic policy subsequently became a source of controversy and led to the emergence of the Hindi movement.

Around this period, two publications, one by Babu Shiva Prasad and another by Madan Mohan Malviya, contributed significantly to bolstering the Hindi movement. In 1868, Babu Shiva Prasad published a memorandum on court characters, in which he highlighted the adverse effects of the use of Urdu in the North-Western Provinces and Oudh (administrative province in British India). Similarly, Madan Mohan Malviya’s *Court Character and Primary Education in the North-Western Provinces and Oudh* expressed concern over the detrimental impact of officially encouraging Urdu among a Hindu population. At the same time, pro-Urdu campaigns also emerged. Thus, the controversy increasingly moved beyond pamphlets and petitions, giving rise to various organised efforts.

In independent India, the Hindi-Urdu controversy continued to be a divisive political issue, particularly in north India. The persistence of antagonism towards Urdu is especially striking in a country where English, a language of foreign origin, continues to be widely valued and institutionalised across regions. In contrast, Urdu, despite its historical and cultural roots in the Indian subcontinent, continues to encounter hostility.

Decoding the transition to alternative fuels

While adoption of EVs has risen in the passenger vehicles category, it is mainly two-wheeler and three-wheeler categories that are adopting EVs than cars

DATA POINT

Sachin Swaraj
Gandla Sneha

August 2026 marked a notable milestone in India’s journey towards a shift from fossil-fuel run vehicles to Electric Vehicles (EVs), as the data from the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations’ (FADA) showed that it was a period of a “historic fuel crossover”.

In the passenger vehicles category that mainly includes cars, FADA data showed that, for the first time, the share of new vehicles in the alternative fuels category (41.95%) overtook the share of petrol vehicles (40.85%). FADA’s statement said that alternative fuels included “CNG, hybrid and electric combined”.

Without doubt, India has made considerable progress in moving away from fossil fuels and adapting EVs. As **Chart 1** shows, petrol and diesel still dominate the market by a huge margin, accounting for 83.5% of all the roughly 82 lakh vehicles registered from January to March this year. But this is a sharp 11.5 percentage points drop from the same period in 2021, when petrol and diesel accounted for over 95% of all the 57 lakh vehicles registered then.

Less adoption among cars

While the chart shows the sale of EVs on a sharp increase, accounting for 10.6% of total registrations, a granular analysis of sub-categories under the alternative fuels based on data accessed from the Vahan portal showed that this was driven more by EV adoption in the two-wheeler and three-wheeler categories. When it came to cars, the growth under the alternative fuels is more pronounced in vehicles that use CNG and LPG, which are fossil fuels with significantly lower emissions, than EVs.

The two-wheeler segment which accounts for over 70% of all

the new vehicles registered in the country had shown signs that EV adoption is gaining pace.

After registering a marginal increase year-on-year, the share of EVs in two-wheelers has made a jump from 6.4% in 2025 to 9.1% in 2026 (till August) (**Chart 2**). This is also the first time the share of two-wheelers running on petrol has come down to the 90% mark. This jump in the sale of EV two-wheelers has contributed significantly to the overall share of petrol and diesel vehicles, across all categories, coming down well below the 85% mark this year.

If there is one segment that has made a rapid transition away from petrol and diesel, it is the three-wheeler category. They, however, account for only 4% of all the vehicles sold. Of the roughly 9.8 lakh three-wheelers registered till August this year, 60.5% have been EVs (**Chart 3**). The share of petrol and diesel in the registration of three-wheelers has halved from nearly 30% in 2021 to less than 15% in 2026. Interestingly, the share of three-wheelers using CNG or LPG has also come down this year.

It is in the cars segment, which accounts for the second biggest share in vehicles after two-wheelers, that the picture is more nuanced than what the shift indicates when “alternative fuels” are clubbed together. **Chart 4** shows a remarkable drop in the share of petrol and diesel cars from 86% in 2021 to 61.6% in 2026.

However, this decline is because there are more hybrid cars that run on petrol with CNG or LNG than EVs. There is certainly progress in the sale of EVs, but it is much slower when compared to vehicles using CNG or LPG. The share of hybrid EVs has remained fairly constant since 2023 at around eight per cent. The data indicates the need for further interventions through measures such as the ramping up of charging infrastructure, which can help accelerate the pace of EV adoption among cars as well.

Nuance in the mix

The data for the charts were sourced from the Vahan portal. Values for 2026 are till August. Vehicles in few other fuel categories with negligible share in total registrations are not shown in the charts. Sachin Swaraj and Gandla Sneha are interning with The Hindu’s Data team



CHART 1: The lines show the total number of vehicles registered in each fuel category while the values within brackets show the share of each fuel type in total vehicles registered. Q1 - Jan to March, Q2 - Apr to June, Q3 - July to Sep, Q4 - Oct to Nov

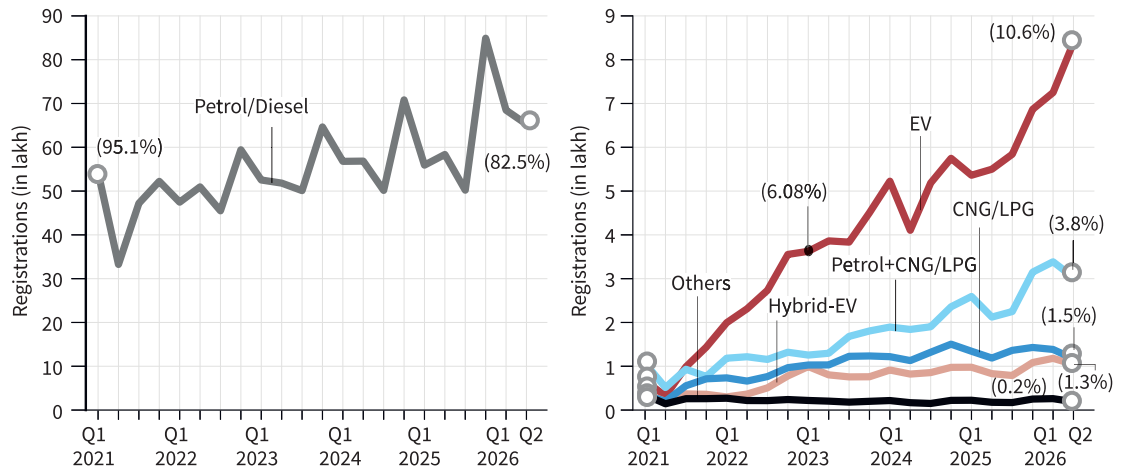
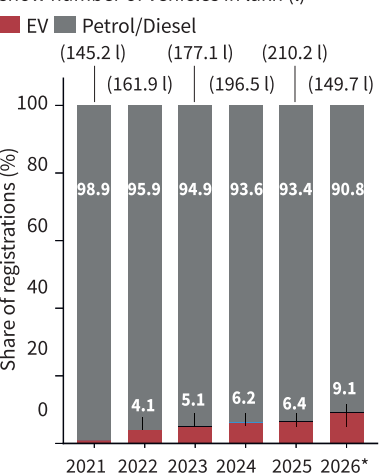
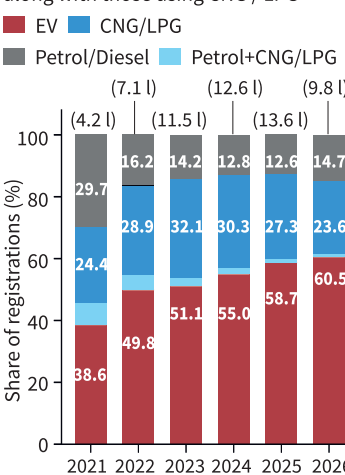


CHART 2: Share of EVs in two-wheelers has shown a notable jump in 2026. Values above bars in Charts 2, 3 and 4 show number of vehicles in lakh (l)



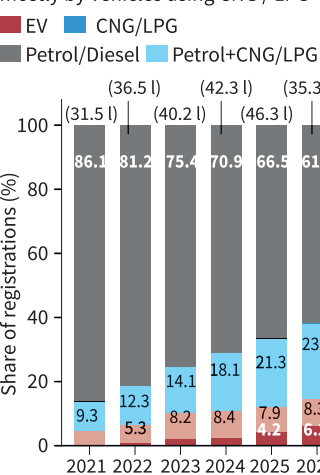
For the first time, the sale of petrol vehicles in the number of new two-wheelers registered has dropped to 90% mark in 2026

CHART 3: EVs now dominate three-wheelers, while share of vehicles using petrol/diesel have come down sharply along with those using CNG / LPG



The share of EVs among three-wheelers has jumped from less than 40% in 2021 to over 60% in 2026

CHART 4: While share of petrol and diesel vehicles in sale of cars has come down, their share is replaced mostly by vehicles using CNG / LPG



The share of petrol/diesel vehicles has come down significantly, but share of EVs is growing only marginally

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 22, 1976

Chavan asks passport officers to be quick, alert

New Delhi, September 21: The External Affairs Minister, Mr. Y.B. Chavan, to-day set for the passport officers in the country the twin task of being efficient and quick in the disposal of passport applications while at the same time guarding against organised activities of spurious agents and touts.

Addressing the nine Regional Passport Officers in the country, Mr. Chavan said that these might “look rather contradictory, but they are infact, not.” What was demanded of them, he said, was “awareness, alertness and vigilance combined with efficiency and courtesy.”

This was all the more so because of the increasing number of people who sought passports. Perhaps passport offices were the only instrument through which the External Affairs Ministry came in constant touch with the public and thus the working of the Ministry would be judged by the public by the way they functioned.

Unlike in the past, all categories of people, skilled and unskilled went abroad, particularly because of India’s economic co-operation with several developing countries. It should be remembered that there were certain organised agencies to commit economic offences. Passport was an important instrument for such offences across the national boundaries and this activity, he said was “quite considerable”.

It was, therefore, important for the Passport Officers, to be vigilant while at the same time being courteous to those who approached them.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 22, 1926

Hooliganism in Russia

Riga, September 21: A message from Moscow says that hooliganism is so alarming all over Russia that it is unsafe to walk after dark in less frequented streets even in Moscow and Leningrad. All classes of people in town and country are demanding that the Government should take up the matter. Many assaults on girls and other acts of violence are reported. Workmen’s clubs are forming unofficial bodies of police for self-protection.

At a meeting convened to discuss the situation, the Commissar of Interior recommended that the worst offenders should be shot as was already being done in Ukraine.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Ethiopian armed groups announcing anti-govt. alliance

7 Seven Ethiopian armed groups said they have formed an alliance aimed at overthrowing Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed's government. The announcement of the Ethiopian Peoples' Forces Alliance for Survival brought together diverse groups ranging from Tigray in the north to the Somali Region in the south. REUTERS

Number of vehicles fined for illegal parking in Keralam

32,385 The Traffic and Road Safety Management wing of Keralam Police has collected ₹1.08 crore in fines from 32,385 vehicles for traffic violations, mainly illegal parking, during a Statewide seven-day inspection, police said. PTI

Number of vacancies in J&K government departments

40,672 In reply to questions from MLAs Sajad Lone and Irfan Hafeez Lone about recruitment and vacancies, the government said there were 40,672 vacancies across various government departments. PTI

Predicted decline in Maharashtra's sugar production

20 in per cent. Sugar production in Maharashtra may fall by nearly 20% in the upcoming crushing season, according to the West India Sugar Mills Association (WISMA). It said Maharashtra has faced a severe rain shortfall this year that adversely affected various crop yields. PTI

Amount of fine on Google by the EU for data location breach

403 in € million. Ireland's data protection watchdog, acting on behalf of the European Union, said on Monday that it had fined Google €403 million (\$462 million) for improperly using users' location data. AFP
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why did the SC reject methanol rules?

What did the Supreme Court find wrong with Maharashtra's methanol rules? Why did the court hold the methanol restrictions disproportionate? What constitutional rights did the impugned rules violate? What guidelines did the Supreme Court issue to prevent tragedies?

EXPLAINER

Rizmi Lia M.

The story so far:

In September 18, the Supreme Court struck down Maharashtra government rules requiring methanol to be denatured with a colourant and bitterant before sale to non-drug manufacturers, holding that the measures were disproportionate and lacked sufficient connection with the problem they sought to address. A Bench, including J.B. Pardiwala and K. Vinod Chandran, allowed the writ petitions filed by the methanol-based product manufacturers against the mandatory inclusion of additives in methanol because of amendments to the Maharashtra Poisons Rules, 1972.

What was the case about?

Methanol, or methyl alcohol, is a highly toxic substance. It is also widely used as an industrial raw material in products including formaldehyde, paraformaldehyde, paints, resins and other chemicals.

The Maharashtra government introduced stricter controls on methanol following a 1991 hooch tragedy in Mumbai, in which around 93 people died after consuming spurious liquor containing methanol. A committee headed by then Additional Director General of Police P.R. Parthasarthy was constituted to examine the causes of the tragedy and suggest measures.

In 2011, Maharashtra amended its Poisons Rules and introduced Rules 18A and 18B.

The petitioners are aggrieved by the operation of the impugned Rules 18A and 18B of the Maharashtra Poisons Rules, respectively, which restrict the purchase of methanol and mandate the addition of bitterant and colourant to methanol before sale to a non-drug manufacturer. Further, by operation of Rule 18B, any possession of methanol without a licence in Form A is liable to confiscation.

Companies told the court that colour contamination could make products



GETTY IMAGES

unacceptable to the paint and pharmaceutical industries, while the additives could affect catalysts, laboratory and pharmaceutical applications.

The State, however, argued that the rules were necessary because methanol could be mixed with liquor and cause fatal poisoning. Making methanol identifiable and bitter would help prevent its misuse, it added.

What did the court examine?

The central question was whether Rules 18A and 18B violated Articles 14 and 19(1)(g) of the Constitution.

The basic tenet of Article 14 is fairness in action and non-arbitrariness, while Article 19(1)(g) protects the right to carry on an occupation, trade or business. The court said that the State does have the power to regulate methanol. The Poisons Act, 1919 permits State governments to make rules regulating the possession and sale of poisons. But the question before the court was whether Rules 18A and 18B, respectively, of the Maharashtra Poisons Rules could be said to be arbitrary, disproportionate, and unreasonable.

What was the ruling?

The Supreme Court held that the impugned provisions of the Maharashtra Poisons Rules, 1972, were unconstitutional.

The court found that Rule 18A(1), which

required verification of a purchaser's Form A licence before methanol could be sold, imposed a disproportionate restriction on legitimate industrial users. The court held that merely verifying a Form A licence did not establish how the purchaser would use methanol.

The court also struck down Rule 18A(2), which required methanol sold to non-drug manufacturers to be mixed with a colourant and bitterant. It held that the requirement did not have a reasonable and proximate nexus with preventing the misuse of methanol in illicit liquor. The State failed to demonstrate that the additives would prevent diversion or manufacture of spurious liquor.

"What is discernable from the above is that in practicality, the impugned rules prescribe a regulatory framework that does not prevent the misuse of methanol in liquor which takes place in the unregulated field. The sub-rule even in the best case of full compliance cannot prevent the misuse it aims to prevent... It addresses a mischief, it does not in fact remedy while imposing a continuous burden on the industries," it observed.

As for Rule 18B, which provided for confiscation of methanol possessed without a Form A licence, the court found that it could conflict with the lawful possession of methanol under a Form B permit and effectively render that permit redundant. The provision, therefore, also

failed the proportionality test.

Applying the proportionality framework laid down in *K.S. Puttaswamy v. Union of India* (2017), the court held that although the prevention of loss of life from methanol-adulterated liquor constituted a legitimate aim, the impugned restrictions were neither suitable nor necessary to achieve that objective. The court consequently allowed the writ petitions, disposed of the connected civil appeal, and held that the impugned rules were violative of Articles 14 and 19(1)(g). The court noted that "a policy that is irrational, or lacks rational justification, or is violative of any constitutional, statutory or any other provision of law is liable to be struck down".

What were the guidelines?

The court passed the guidelines regarding important aspects and steps to prevent hooch tragedies and for effective implementation of the policies.

The court said States should work together through the prohibition, excise, police, transport, industries and health departments, along with NGOs, to prevent illegal liquor. This includes checking State borders, stopping illegal transport, identifying places where illicit liquor is made or stored, and monitoring industrial units that may illegally supply chemicals used to make spurious liquor.

As regards the existing rules in States/Union Territories, the court said methanol rules should be strengthened. Licences should be granted only after proper verification and should be regularly reviewed. Industrial users should return unused or excess methanol, maintain proper stock and consumption records, and face suspension or cancellation of licences for violations. Methanol should be transported in dedicated tankers under excise supervision and sealed in a way that prevents theft, diversion or tampering.

It also called for more de-addiction centres, support for affected families and local counselling centres.

The court added that while it could issue directions, effective implementation ultimately depends on the police and enforcement machinery.

THE GIST

▼ The Supreme Court struck down Maharashtra's rules requiring methanol sold to non-drug manufacturers to be denatured with colourant and bitterant, finding them disproportionate and unconstitutional under Articles 14 and 19(1)(g)

▼ It held that the rules did not have a reasonable and proximate nexus with preventing methanol misuse in illicit liquor, while imposing continuing burdens on legitimate industries

▼ The court issued guidelines for States to strengthen methanol regulation, including stricter licensing, stock and transport controls, and inter-departmental enforcement

How will Gaganyaan's crew module deploy its parachutes?

Why does Gaganyaan need multiple parachutes? How are they tested?

Unnikrishnan Nair S.

The story so far:

Any spacecraft entering the earth's atmosphere will rely primarily on atmospheric drag to lose a significant fraction of its velocity. To gently touch down on land or in the sea, additional decelerating systems like parachutes have to be activated.

The parachute used for crewed space vehicles demands extraordinary engineering with multi-staging, redundancy, high-performance materials and high-pressure packing to reduce storage space.

How are parachutes deployed?

The parachute system contains three types of chutes: pilot, drogue, and main. The pilot chute is a mini-parachute

deployed to pull out wider drogue or main chutes. The drogue chute is deployed early in the descent to stabilise the module and first reduce the velocity. The main chute has a wider canopy and is used in the final phase to reduce the velocity enough to achieve gentle soft-landing conditions.

The crew module's blunt shape creates a turbulent wake in its rear side and the parachute has to be ejected through this wake. The ejection mechanism should ensure the energy imparted to the parachute suffices to cross the wake in the shortest time and deploy the parachute in the far-wake region.

Generally, the parachutes are deployed when the module has reduced its speed to below the speed of sound.

Why deploy parachutes in stages?

As it descends, the Gaganyaan crew

module will be moving at around 170 m/s in the lower atmosphere. If the full-sized main parachute is deployed straightaway, it will experience a high opening shock, shredding the fabric or subjecting the crew to dangerously high deceleration.

Multi-staging, on the other hand, increases the chutes' diameter in successive stages, keeping the dynamic pressure to acceptable levels.

Also, to keep a chute from opening really quickly, a cord wound around the canopy restricts how far it can spread. After a preset delay, when the vehicle has slowed enough, a timed cutter severs the cord, which goes loose and allows the parachute to bloom fully.

How are parachutes tested?

There are different platforms to test parachutes. The 'rail track rocket sled' is a ground facility where a sled is accelerated

along rails by firing small solid motors, and the parachutes are deployed from the sled at an appropriate velocity. The Terminal Ballistic Research Lab, Chandigarh, has a state-of-the-art RTRS facility.

Other modes of testing include dropping the test article from a helicopter or an aircraft or using small rocket-powered test vehicles, which launch the crew module to some appropriate altitude and release it from there.

After splashdown in the sea or upon soft-landing on land, if the parachute is not detached immediately, the wind acting on the canopy could drag the module on land or capsize it in sea and this might cause injuries to the astronauts. Hence, the parachute is released by activating pyro cutters or mechanical quick-release devices.

What materials are used in aerospace parachutes?

A parachute's material is controlled by conditions like tensile strength, thermal resistance, and mass. Modern aerospace parachutes use advanced synthetic polymers engineered to meet specific design conditions.

Kevlar is used in high-load suspension lines, risers, and structural reinforcement tapes due to its exceptional tensile

strength and heat resistance. Nomex finds application in heat-exposed areas to withstand hot mortar gas discharge and aerothermal heating.

Nylon is widely used for canopy broadcloths because of its elasticity, which helps absorb initial dynamic shock loads during inflation. It is highly compressible, so it can be packed into a relatively small volume.

What parachutes are in the Gaganyaan crew module?

In crewed missions, recovery systems use redundant clusters of pilot, drogue, and main parachutes. The Gaganyaan crew module has two drogue chutes deployed by mortars and three main chutes deployed by mortar-ejected pilot chutes.

If one main parachute suffers an anomaly, the remaining two independent chains are fully capable of ensuring a safe touchdown.

ADRDE in Agra, which is a laboratory under the Defence Research & Development Organisation, is the developing agency.

(Unnikrishnan Nair S. is former director, VSSC and IIST; Founding Director, HSFC; and an expert in launch vehicle systems, orbital re-entry and human spaceflight technologies. Currently Dr Sarabhay Professor at VSSC)

ABSTRACT

Parental demand, education markets and the spread of ideologies

Hindutva is spreading through everyday interactions in the education market, with parents playing a role in shaping school decisions; marketisation allows majoritarian preferences to be expressed as consumer demands, with schools accommodating them while sidelining minority concerns

Rebecca Rose Varghese

Arora-Kukreja Ritika, ‘Hindutva by Other Means: The Educational Market and the Politics of Demand’, *Economic and Political Weekly*, Vol 61 Issue No. 34, August 22, 2026

Recently, an advertisement for a jewellery brand featuring a Bollywood actress during Raksha Bandhan was taken down by the brand following public outrage over her attire, which some considered insufficiently modest for a traditional festival. While there were debates over whether her dressing should be judged in such a manner, the brand eventually took down the advertisement and apologised to a section of the public, responding to pressure from a majoritarian opinion.

In another incident, a Muslim IPS officer in Bengal was transferred after Hindutva groups criticised her for using an Islamic greeting on social media. While the government and its nationalist ideologies may have their own role in such incidents, public pressure in this case was an important factor that resulted in her immediate transfer.

In both these cases, the institution or management responded to the majoritarian or dominant public view.

When we think about how ideologies spread and become embedded in everyday life, we often assume that the state apparatus plays the primary role, using its institutions and various forms of authority to promote particular ideas. What we often overlook, however, is the influence of the majoritarian public itself.

Public pressure, consumer choices, social expectations and everyday interactions can also become important channels through which an ideology is reproduced and normalised.

One of the best locations to examine the spread of political and religious ideologies is schools, because history shows how the moulding of young minds can become a central aspect of ideological reproduction.

Studies have shown how state apparatuses have often been used to promote particular political and social ideologies through education. Hindutva is one such right-wing political ideology of Hindu nationalism that seeks to define India’s cultural and national identity through Hindu values and heritage and influence public policy, which the state has promoted through schools in India.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led governments, both during the 1998-2004 period and from 2014 to date, have used the state’s power over curriculum and regulation to advance a particular vision of Indian nationhood. This literature has produced a robust analytical vocabulary to think of saffronisation as a product of a state-led project: the deliberate use of state institutional capacity to reshape the content and culture around education in a way that resonates with the Hindu majoritarian conception of the nation.

But is this the only way Hindutva enters schools? Are there no other players?

While the state may have a direct role in shaping government schools, what about spaces where its hold is less direct, particularly private urban schools that often present themselves as modern, cosmopolitan and removed from such



Growing influence: In the education market, parents express their preferences, which school management responds to and incorporates into its decisions. THULASI KAKKAT

ideological concerns?

Think of the first two examples in the context of such schools. This is what author Ritika Arora-Kukreja does in her article.

The article is particularly relevant as it examines other factors that have helped push Hindutva ideology into schools. The paper argues that Hindutva is increasingly spreading through everyday interactions in the education market, not just through government policies or Hindutva organisations. This side of education has largely been overlooked by both the literature on marketisation and the literature on saffronisation.

Through in-depth interviews and focus group methods with households with children, and interviews with school leaders across private schools in Delhi-NCR between April and September 2022, the author analyses the increasing role of parents as actors pushing for Hindutva ideologies to spread in Indian schools.

From regulation to market demand

The Nehruvian model of education after independence was such that the state provided, regulated and directly controlled institutions. But after the 1991 liberalisation reforms, the relationship between the state and institutions, especially schools, changed drastically. With privatisation, the middle and upper-middle classes, especially in urban India, started attending private schools, where state control was extremely limited. The author explains that in Delhi, where she did her study, private-school enrollment at the primary and middle levels increased from around 30% in 2014-15 to over 46% in 2019-20. So while the state did not disappear and still continued to spread ideologies through

the curriculum and syllabus, its role in directly influencing and promoting ideologies had its limits.

The state was then replaced by market demands, especially those of the dominant middle and upper-middle classes. Parental preferences started taking precedence over the state apparatus and shaped decisions made by school management.

For instance, if parents do not approve of the appointment of a Muslim teacher due to the fear that they may promote Islam, they are not admitted. Or if the majority of parents are vegetarian, the school may make a rule that non-vegetarian food should not be brought for lunch, which inevitably affects children from other religions and cultures. Schools succumb to the demands of the dominant group while sidelining minorities, fearing the repercussions of not doing so.

The Hindu customer

Strong competition between schools, combined with the majoritarian population in a region, creates what the author calls the “Hindu customer”, whose demands have to be met by school management. Highlighting Hindu festivals in schools, giving holidays for them, deliberately not admitting students from certain religious groups, and attempting to ban the hijab from schools are some examples. The author calls this “hyper-accountability”.

While marketisation is supposed to make schools more accountable by giving parents more power and making schools depend on parent satisfaction, in this context, schools are focused on satisfying the majority. The concerns of minority families are ignored, as their dissatisfaction will have a smaller

economic impact on schools.

Here, it is the Hindu customer who is being satisfied. Instead of being seen just as a religious identity, they attain the identity of a powerful customer in the education market, whose demands cannot be ignored.

Their economic power, combined with the growing political legitimacy of Hindu nationalism, ensures that schools meet their demands while trying to present them as reasonable. For instance, instead of citing religious reasons, schools use hygiene to justify banning non-vegetarian food and security to justify banning the hijab, while the same concerns are not applied to visual symbols of other religious groups.

Political demands as choices

One of the ways in which such demands are justified and seen as rational or reasonable is through what the author calls the “depoliticisation of choices”. The demands or preferences of parents are seen as individual, private consumer choices rather than politically coloured ones. Marketisation literature often presents this in simple terms: the parent has a demand, and the market responds to it.

It therefore becomes important to understand how these preferences are formed. The author explains how citizens are influenced on a daily basis by ideas of Hindu nationalism through news media, social media, neighbourhoods and other forms of political socialisation. Their choices about education therefore also reflect these political and cultural ideas.

The market does not necessarily create these preferences. Instead, it provides a system where such preferences can be expressed as legitimate consumer demands and accommodated by schools that depend on satisfying their consumers. The author explains that the education market does not only reproduce class inequalities. In contemporary India, it can also provide an institutional space for religious-nationalist preferences to enter and shape education.

Challenging the ideology spread

Challenging the spread of Hindutva or other religious ideologies in schools is important because education shapes young and impressionable minds and can influence how they understand religion and society. To do so, it is necessary to understand how such ideologies enter educational spaces.

Existing saffronisation literature has mainly focused on the role of the state and political organisations. The author draws attention to another channel, which she calls “bottom-up Hindutva”. Unlike state-led Hindutva, which spreads from state institutions and political organisations into society, “bottom-up Hindutva” describes a process in which preferences and demands from society shape institutions. In the education market, parents express their preferences, which school management responds to and incorporates into their decisions. The paper is therefore important because it highlights other ways in which religious ideologies can spread, which need to be closely examined to understand and challenge their influence in education. (Rebecca Rose Varghese is a freelance journalist)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of the expression “to go bananas”?(R. Pillai, Chennai)

This expression has several different meanings. When someone goes bananas about/over something, he/she becomes very enthusiastic about it. The expression is considered slang and is generally used in informal contexts. Here are a few examples.

The students went bananas when they heard that Mani was going to address them.

We all went bananas when we saw Steffi Graf walk into the gym.

To go bananas can also mean to drive someone crazy or mad. For example, *The constant questions made him go bananas.*

When used in this sense, “to go bananas” means the same thing as “to go nuts” and “to go crazy”. “Cool bananas” is an expression that is frequently used in American English as an exclamation. It is often used to mean “wow”.

Satish got an A in the exam. Cool bananas!

What is the correct pronunciation of the word “harass”?(B. Devarajan, Hubli)

The manner in which you pronounce this word will, to a large extent, depend on which side of the Atlantic you are from. For example, if you are from England, then you would tend to pronounce the first “a” like the “a” in “cat”, “bat” and “act”. The second would be pronounced like the “a” in “China,” and the main stress would be on the first syllable. If, on the other hand, you come from the U.S., then you would do the exact opposite. You would pronounce the first “a” like the “a” in “China” and the second “a” like the “a” in “cat”. The stress in this case would be on the second syllable.

What is the meaning and origin of the expression “trailblazer”?(P. Anuradha, Hyderabad)

A trailblazer is someone who is the first to do something. For example, he or she could be someone who has discovered or developed a new method of doing something. Here are a few examples.

Jambu will always be remembered as a trailblazer in cancer research.

Padma was a trailblazer in the field of AIDS research.

One can even talk about an individual or an institution of having “blazed a trail”. When someone blazes a trail, what you are implying is that he/she has done something that no one has done before; something that will benefit a lot of other people.

The company has blazed a trail in developing new medicines for curing AIDS.

The word “blaze” is generally associated with “fire”. So “trailblazer” should be someone who develops something new by destroying everything that is old. This, however, is not the origin of the expression. The expression came into being in the late 18th Century when the American settlers were pushing further and further west – towards Oregon, California, etc. Since they were exploring uncharted territory and didn’t want to get lost along the way, they used to mark the trail that they had taken.

One of the ways that they used to indicate the route they had taken was to remove the bark from some of the trees. This method of marking trees was known as “blazing”. And since they were marking a trail, we get the expressions “blazing a trail” and “trailblazer”. Published in *The Hindu* on January 8, 2002

THE DAILY QUIZ

September 22 marks the 40th anniversary of the second tied Test match in the history of cricket. How much do you remember about this historic India-Australia Test?

Soorya Prakash N.

QUESTION 1

Who is the only person connected with both the first and second tied Test matches?

QUESTION 2

Who were declared as players in the match from the respective sides?

QUESTION 3

While Greg Matthews took five in both innings, which other Australian bowler took the remaining five Indian wickets in their second innings?

QUESTION 4

Who became the first player to make 100 consecutive Test appearances during this historic Test?

QUESTION 5

Who deputised for regular Wicketkeeper Kiran More after he left the field on the first day due to food poisoning?

QUESTION 6

Who was the Wicketkeeper of Australia in that Test?

QUESTION 7

Which Indian allrounder remained unbeaten with a gritty 48 after ensuring that India would not lose that Test match?



Visual Question:

Identify the Umpire who declared the last man, Maninder Singh, out LBW? THE HINDU ARCHIVES

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. A man with a realistic dog’s head and one leg in a cast wanders through New York City with a boombox. **Ans: Daft Punk - Da Funk**
2. A gymnast, played by Sofia Coppola, walks into a packed school sports hall to face a favoured rival. **Ans: The Chemical Brothers - Elektrobank**
3. A Frenchman wakes up, gets ready, and arrives in his customized car to compete in a car-audio decibel contest. **Ans: DJ Mehdi - Signature**
4. A kid on a metro discovers that the music player in his hand can pause, rewind and fast-forward the real world. A classic! **Ans: Bomfunk MC’s - Freestyler**
5. Shot in black and white, two men walk towards the camera as their t-shirts come alive with colourful typography. **Ans: Justice - D.A.N.C.E.**
6. A group of children with telekinetic powers escape a facility, test their abilities and wait to join the outside world. **Ans: M83 - Midnight City**
Visual: Identify the music video from the screengrab shown. It won the Film Craft Grand Prix in 2017. **Ans: The Blaze - Territory**
Early Birds: Tamal Biswas | Piyali Tuli | Sukdev Shet | Tito Shiladitya | Prem Raj P.

• INDEX

Aerospace suppliers test rare-earth alternatives



Near monopoly: The flag of China is placed next to the elements of Gallium and Germanium. REUTERS

Reuters

Rare earth shortages are pushing some suppliers of aerospace companies to revisit decades-old turbine coating formulas once considered obsolete, after U.S.-China tensions disrupted supplies from the world's dominant producer of critical minerals. China has a near monopoly on rare earths and materials such as yttrium, indium phosphide and tungsten, which are used in a range of aerospace and defence systems, including jet engine coatings, turbine components and semiconductor chips.

Despite early efforts, producers of coatings for aerospace remain years away from replacing modern rare-earth-based materials, or finding adequate supply of rare earths in the U.S., experts say. The renewed interest in decades-old alternatives reflects concerns that supply disruptions and high prices could threaten key parts of the jet-engine supply chain.

The National Research Council (NRC), Canada's primary agency for scientific and industrial research and development, said rare earth shortages were behind industry interest in finding alternatives for the thermal barrier coatings used in the hottest sections of jet engines. The NRC and many industry partners are evaluating if zirconium dioxide and other non rare earth ceramic oxide can be comparable with modern rare-earth-based coatings.

Global diesel squeeze may persist into 2027 as storage tanks steadily drain

North American diesel storage available for lease hits four-year high in October, The Tank Tiger says; U.S. diesel stocks lowest for this time of year on record, EIA says; EIA forecasts United States' distillate inventories below 100 million barrels in the month of September through end-2026

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

A global diesel shortage fuelled by wars in Iran and Ukraine is unlikely to ease before next year, according to storage market indicators and industry participants, extending a spike in fuel costs that is weighing on economies worldwide.

The wars have severely disrupted diesel supplies, stranding millions of barrels a day in the Middle East and Russia, draining inventories to historic lows and sending prices to record highs. The shortage has been a drag on economic activity, as diesel fuels agriculture, manufacturing, and heavy transportation.

In the U.S., retail diesel prices topped \$6 a gallon this month for the first time, squeezing farmers and truckers and stoking worries for President Donald Trump's Republican Party ahead of the November midterm elections.

Another sign of persistent tightness is emerging in the storage market. Refiners and traders across North America are declining to renew diesel storage leases because there is little fuel available to store, data from storage broker The Tank Tiger showed.

Diesel storage capacity



Precious fuel: A worker fills his truck with diesel fuel at a corporate filling station in San Diego, California, U.S. REUTERS

available for leasing in North America and the Caribbean Islands, a major trading hub, has climbed to a four-year high of 13 million barrels for October, from 11 million barrels in June, The Tank Tiger Chief Operating Officer Steven Barsamian told Reuters.

Total U.S. diesel inventories declined to 107.9 million barrels by September 11, the lowest for this time of year since records began in 1982, according to the US Energy Information Administration.

The rapid draw of diesel from U.S. storage indicates how tightly supplied the market has been in recent months, and the rising availability of tanks for lease underscores how long the tightness is expected to persist, Barsa-

mian said.

The combination of falling inventories and rising storage availability suggests market participants expect supplies to remain tight into at least the first quarter of next year, Barsamian said. Storage tanks are typically leased for six months to a year.

"More storage is available for lease because no one wants to renew their

existing contracts. Why would you pay for a storage tank when there is no diesel to store?" Barsamian said.

EcoBox Dumpsters, a U.S. waste management business, is limiting its rising fuel cost by using smaller trucks where possible, grouping deliveries and pickups in the same area, and confirming pickup schedules to avoid unnecessary trips.

"Each unnecessary truck movement now has a much greater cost," said owner David Garrigus.

A global concern

The EIA also expects inventories to stay depleted. "We forecast inventories of distillate fuel oil – often sold as diesel – in the

U.S. to fall below 100 million barrels in September and remain below the five-year low through the end of 2026 and most of 2027," the EIA said earlier this month.

European diesel inventories are also low. Stocks in the Amsterdam-Rotterdam-Antwerp storage, refining and trading hub were 16% below the five-year average in July, according to the latest data available from Insights Global. In Singapore, total distillate inventory levels averaged about 8.2 million barrels over the past few weeks, similar to pre-Iran war levels, but below the 2025 average of 9.6 million.

"Various Asian emerging markets have been affected quite significantly," said Andrea Pescatori, the

International Monetary Fund's Asia-Pacific deputy division chief, at the Asia Pacific Petroleum Conference in Singapore.

Signs of relief

Industry executives expect global diesel supplies to stay tight through winter, particularly if Middle East tensions further disrupt fuel exports and Russia's diesel export ban remains in force through October. Moscow will extend diesel export restrictions until the end of October, Russian business daily Vedomosti reported.

U.S. diesel prices may rise further as U.S. East Coast buyers purchase barrels ahead of the heating season, before peaking, said Alex Hodes, director of energy market strategy at StoneX. Analysts also expect record diesel refining margins to encourage more production, limiting price increases.

The U.S. diesel crack spread – the premium of ultra-low sulfur diesel futures over U.S. crude oil futures – hit a record \$118.62 a barrel on September 14.

Further relief could come from China, which has boosted exports steadily in recent months, energy economist Philip Verleger said this month.

Still, any escalation in the Iran or Russia-Ukraine wars, or a major refinery outage, could trigger fresh price spikes.

Tata Sons' board row with majority-owner Tata Trusts widens

EXPLAINER

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The story so far: At a board meeting of Tata Sons on Thursday, the board, following a decision by the Nomination & Remuneration Committee (NRC), asked Executive Chairman N. Chandrasekaran to reconsider his decision of not seeking reappointment, and instead, continue for a period of five years. Mr. Chandrasekaran "acceded to the request" and was re-appointed for the third term starting February 2027. This has now sparked off a back-and-forth between Tata Sons and Tata Trusts.

Board members

The board members include Mr. Chandrasekaran (Chairman), Venu Srinivasan (Tata Trusts nominee director), Noel Tata (Tata Trusts nominee director), Harish Manwani (Independent Director), Saurabh Agarwal (Executive Director & CFO), and Anita M. George (Independent Director).

After this, the board "thereafter" resolved by a majority vote to re-appoint him as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years upon the expiry of his current tenure. Four directors, other than Noel Tata, voted in favour of the resolution. Tata Trusts, which holds a 66% stake in Tata Sons, termed the reappointment decision as illegal since Noel Tata voted against it.

The Tata Sons board also resolved to initiate steps to comply with the applicable RBI guidelines and decided it would seek guidance from the RBI, Tata Trusts and other stakehol-

ders on applicable compliance requirements.

Earlier, on September 11, the RBI rejected Tata Son's application for de-registration of its Core Investment Company NBFC licence and asked it to instantly comply with the regulations, which has been interpreted by some as ordering it go for mandatory listing.

Opting out

On August 12, Mr Chandrasekaran, in a letter to the board, expressed his desire not to seek reappointment after the expiry of his tenure, stating it lacked unanimity as one board member [Noel Tata] did not approve it.

Board's decision

The Tata Sons Board stated it received from Tata Trusts an unanimous resolution dated July 28, 2025, expressing appreciation of Mr. Chandrasekaran for his stewardship of the Group from 2017. In recognition of these efforts, Tata Trusts resolved he be re-appointed as Executive Chairman for a further five years. Subsequently, in September, the board of Tata Sons agreed in principle to re-appoint Mr Chandrasekaran as Executive Chairman for five more years.

Pursuant to the applicable provisions of the law, the board decided to seek relevant formal approval in February 2026. But, in the absence of unanimity, the resolution was deferred. In the subsequent board meetings in May and June, the matter was discussed but not resolved.

On August 12, Mr Chandrasekaran opted not to offer himself for reappointment. But on September 3, the NRC of the board of Tata Sons [comprising Mr. Srinivasan, Mr. Manwani & Ms. George] met to discuss



Key players: Combined file image of N. Chandrasekaran (L) and Noel Tata (R). PTI/REUTERS

his letter and the issue of reappointment.

"After due deliberation and in recognition of his contributions and the larger interests of the Tata Group, the NRC unanimously resolved to request him to reconsider his decision and to recommend him for reappointment at the next board meeting [that took place on Thursday]," Tata Sons said.

The dispute now

Tata Trusts, the majority owner of Tata Trusts, with a 66% holding, via Chairman Noel Tata voted against the resolutions & decisions of the Tata Sons Board. The Trusts said Mr Chandrasekaran, having already expressed his desire to opt out, cannot now revisit his decision on reappointment as it had been "duly accepted and has attained finality".

As per the Trusts, this decision was freely taken, clearly expressed and was not the outcome of any review process. It was made public without prior intimation or any deliberations with the shareholders of the firm. Once such a decision was publicly communicated, it had consequences that cannot be afterwards undone, since

the Group's staff, lenders and counterparties, the market and the majority shareholder had all proceeded on it.

The Tata Trusts said they formally placed on record acceptance of the decision the following day (August 13) and advised Tata Sons to initiate the process for setting up a Selection Committee for the appointment of a successor in accordance with the Articles of Association of Tata Sons.

"The Trusts' position remains unchanged, as a considered judgment of a majority shareholder. This position was reiterated in today's Board Meeting by the Chairman, Tata Trusts. The resolution seeking to reappoint Mr. Chandrasekaran at the Board meeting today, with four Directors voting in favour, and Mr. Noel against, was a legal nullity in view of the provisions of the Articles of Association of Tata Sons," Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata said in a statement.

'Reappointment illegal'

As per Tata Trusts, the process for appointing a Chairman of Tata Sons under the Articles of Association requires a majority of the Trusts' Nominee Directors

voting in favour of the resolution. That process applies equally to the first appointment (when Mr. Chandrasekaran was first appointed in 2017) and to reappointing someone who already held office.

"The Board, accordingly, cannot lawfully hold a meeting or pass a resolution on the Chairman's appointment or reappointment unless both nominee directors are present, and cannot validly pass such a resolution unless both nominee directors vote in favour. [In this case the two nominee directors are Venu Srinivasan and Noel Naval Tata]," Tata Trusts Chairman said.

Given Mr. Noel, being one of the Trust nominee directors, voted against the proposal, it was rendered legally void and without any basis though the other nominee director Venu Srinivasan voted in favour.

Justice D.Y. Chandrachud (former Chief Justice of India) gave a legal opinion regarding the correctness of the Trusts' stand.

Trusts on RBI order

Tata Trusts asked Tata Sons to explore options other than listing and "save" the Tata model. It completely opposed the listing to preserve the more-than-a-century-old structure of Tata Sons and the Tata Group.

As per Tata Trusts, the Tata Sons Board had already considered the matter of public listing and reached a unanimous conclusion in March 2024, under the guidance of the late Ratan Tata, and resolved the firm remain unlisted.

In July 2025, the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust unanimously passed resolutions stating the firm should remain unlisted and the same was communicated

to Tata Sons for action.

Opposition to listing

According to the Trusts, Tata Sons is not a holding company in the ordinary sense. About 66% of equity is held by the Tata Trusts. Dividends received from the operating companies flow, through the Trusts, into public charity.

The argument is the interests which Tata Trusts bring to this Board is public interest held for the millions of beneficiaries of the charities on which the dividends of this firm sustain.

Commercial enterprise and philanthropy were not adjacent to one another but are one structure seen from two ends.

That structure is more than a 100 years old and it permitted this company to act, repeatedly, in ways that a purely commercial calculus would not have supported, Mr Noel said.

The Tata Group was conceived as an instrument of national service through business and had remained committed to that purpose for more than 100 years and the distinctive ownership structure had enabled the group to sustain this character over time, the Tata Trusts argued.

The principal activity of the firm was to invest in and support the Tata Group firms. If Tata Sons is publicly listed, the rights of Tata Trusts as majority shareholders stand to be seriously impaired.

A listed Tata Sons would be accountable to institutional and foreign shareholders whose legitimate interest is financial return. It is doubtful such shareholders would sanction the deployment of capital to rescue a Group firm in distress or the funding of a greenfield venture whose

returns lay 15 years away, the Trusts reasoned.

"What is at stake is something very fundamental. The nature and character of the Tata Group as a unique institution," Tata Trusts stated. A listing will destroy its character and strike at the heart of this principle, Mr. Noel said.

SP Group view

Shapoorji Pallonji Group Chairman Shapoorji Pallonji Mistry "wholeheartedly" welcomed the RBI's decision on the status of Tata Sons and supported its listing for the sake of transparency, accountability, fairness and responsible institution-building.

He said a transparent and publicly accountable Tata Sons can strengthen the entire ecosystem, broaden participation, enhance governance, give greater visibility to value, protect the legitimate interests of investors and provide the basis for a more robust and equitable dividend policy.

"Most importantly, it can strengthen the capacity of the Tata Trusts to pursue philanthropic responsibilities over generations," Mr. Mistry stated. "From my side, I want to make my views unequivocally clear. I look forward to working closely and constructively with Tata Sons on this pathway," he stated.

RBI communication

The September 11 communication received from the RBI records the company's request for voluntary surrender of its certificate of registration cannot be acceded to and advises the firm to take necessary actions to ensure full compliance, immediately, with the guidelines and instructions applicable to a non-banking financial company in the Upper Layer.

The communication

does not specifically mention listing. It prescribes no particular step and it does not say that the company is in breach.

The RBI has not held the company's reasoning to be wrong, Tata Trusts has argued. It has declined an application for voluntary surrender of registration sans providing any reasons. The RBI's decision to lodge caveats in anticipation of a challenge to its order is an unusual step for a regulator.

Tata Trusts further said the same RBI's Scale Based Regulations, which require an Upper Layer NBFC to mandatorily list, also explicitly provides for an Upper Layer NBFC to exit the enhanced regulatory framework.

The board must explore all avenues and possibilities to move out of the regulatory framework that requires mandatory listing and engage fully with the RBI for this purpose, Mr Tata said.

What Tata Trusts want

Tata Trusts wants Tata Sons to make a detailed representation for reconsideration and fully engage with the regulator. It added that the reasons for the rejection must be known.

It has asked Tata Sons to explore all permissible avenues and options to avoid public listing. "There are other options and avenues available. The company can consider restructuring."

"Engage with the regulator immediately upon the question of time. Even assuming for argument's sake that a listing was required and the only option is that the company must list, the company should be given a period of three years to comply. The three-year period should start now," Mr Noel said.



Long wait: People queue to check in at a London airport amid major disruption to air traffic control systems. AFP

In second incident in 2 weeks, U.K. hit by air traffic outage

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

U.K. flights faced fresh disruption Monday, with some cancelled due to a technical issue at the nation's air traffic control agency – the second such outage in two weeks.

The National Air Traffic Services (NATS), plagued by several incidents in recent years, apologised for the latest incident at a centre in Scotland that has since been fixed. “We are working with airports and airlines to... minimise any further disruption,” NATS said in a statement.

It followed an outage on September 8 and 9, when a software glitch caused more than 2,000 U.K. flight cancellations and numerous delays, affecting more than 3,30,000 passengers.

In its latest update, aviation analytics firm Cirium said 72 out of more than 6,000 flights to or from the U.K. had been cancelled. “If this were the end of the day... this level of cancellations is close to normal – around one percent,” it noted in a statement. “However, as it's early in the day, we anticipate that operational performance will degrade quickly.”

It added that while Glasgow and Belfast had experienced “high cancellations... London-area airports are not particularly impacted”.

Transport Minister Heidi Alexander acknowledged that the new incident, which she referred to on X as an “IT issue”, “will be deeply frustrating for passengers after the previous issue”.

Irish airline Ryanair once more called for the resignation of NATS chief executive Martin Rolfe – who received Downing Street's backing following the incident earlier this month.

The travel chaos earlier this month followed a technical glitch in July 2025 that saw scores of flights to and from the U.K. cancelled, prompting anger from airline chiefs. Britain suffered its worst air systems failure in years in 2023, with more than 7,00,000 passengers affected after hundreds of flights were delayed or cancelled.

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

Before taking over the sprawling Justice Department investigation into foes of President Donald Trump, Joe diGenova decried the lack of progress in bringing indictments.

Five months later, Mr. diGenova has left his position without charging a single case, clouding the future of an investigation that has animated right-wing commentators eager to prove an ill-defined theory of a “deep state” conspiracy to take down the Republican President.

Justice Department officials are pressing forward despite Mr. diGenova's departure, with a flurry of subpoenas to former law enforcement and intelligence officials expected to yield grand jury testimony in the weeks ahead at the Fort Pierce, Florida, home court of a favored Trump-appointed federal judge.

Yet whether anyone ultimately will be charged, and for what, remains an open question. Investigators face not only legal hurdles and personnel upheaval but an impatient White House after more than a year of fits and starts.

The investigation known familiarly as the “grand conspiracy” case is the clearest example yet of the Trump administration's efforts to leverage law enforcement powers to enact retribution on the President's adversaries. The tumult that has defined the probe exposes a

familiar gap between White House demands for speedy action and the Justice Department's ability to craft the President's litany of grievances into a prosecutable case.

The investigation has always been a tough task, aiming to knit together separate FBI probes of Mr. Trump – including related to Russian election interference and his retention of classified documents at his Mar-a-Lago estate in Palm Beach, Florida – into a coherent narrative of a government conspiracy. Prior efforts to investigate the investigators have failed to uncover the kind of criminal misconduct the conspiracy probe aims to prove.

“The idea of connecting all those different investigations into one single conspiracy, there's no basis for that,” retired federal prosecutor Randall Eliason said. “Then, maybe more importantly, there's no basis for an allegation that any one of them was actually a criminal act against Trump. They've all been verified and upheld in one way or another.”

If the mandate is unusual, so, too, was the person picked to lead it.

Mr. diGenova, who's 81, was a top prosecutor in President Ronald Reagan's administration but had been out of government for decades. He made headlines in 2020 after he said a cybersecurity official who attested to the legitimacy of the election Mr. Trump lost to Democrat Joe Biden should be



A Right problem: Trump allies regard the probe as a long-awaited reckoning for ex-state officials they think wronged the President. AFP

“drawn and quartered.” DiGenova apologised after being sued.

A prominent booster of the theory that Mr. Trump was victimised by a “deep state” conspiracy, Mr. diGenova was appointed in April shortly after Mr. Trump ousted Pam Bondi as Attorney General after she struggled to prosecute his foes.

The appointment was heralded by Trump allies who regard the probe as a long-awaited reckoning for former officials they believe wronged the President.

Attorney General Todd Blanche, who took the reins of the department after Ms. Bondi's firing, also trumpeted Mr. diGenova's arrival, writing on social media: “Welcome to the fight, Joel!”

By September 10, Mr. diGenova was gone amid Trump administration frustration with the pace and management of the

probe. His parting comments suggested he didn't see a pathway for imminent indictments.

“If you want indictments where there's no evidence, you have an ethical problem,” he told the New York Post.

Mr. diGenova told AP those comments were taken out of context, adding: “There's plenty of evidence in all of these cases to prove the theories of prosecution. It just takes time to get there, and some people want to get there a little faster than others – and you can't do that.”

‘Complete fiction’

Mr. diGenova was sworn in days after a career national security prosecutor, Maria Medetis Long, was removed from the investigative team after conveying concerns about an investigation into former CIA Director John Brennan. A lawyer for Mr. Brennan has seized on the upheaval,

pointing to the departures as proof that prosecutors who have assessed the evidence have been unpersuaded and pushed aside by a Justice Department angling for indictments at all costs.

“I've spent decades in and around the Justice Department. I've never even conceived of a situation like this,” attorney Ken Wainstein said, in which the Justice Department is “blatantly trying to frame somebody for a crime that is complete fiction.”

He made the comments to a judge last week as he put prosecutors on notice that he intended to attack any indictment of Mr. Brennan on the grounds of vindictive prosecution.

The Justice Department has not announced a replacement for Mr. diGenova, but a team of prosecutors and agents remains at work.

As the Justice Department reeled last year from the bungled handling of the Jeffrey Epstein files, officials eager to change the topic announced a new investigation and a directive from Ms. Bondi, then the Attorney General, to present evidence before a grand jury.

The topic was hardly a surprise to anyone tracking Mr. Trump's grievances.

The President has long been infuriated by a U.S. intelligence community assessment that found that Russia interfered on his behalf in the 2016 election, including by stealing politically damaging Democratic

emails and orchestrating their release through WikiLeaks, and spent much of his first term shadowed by an investigation into whether his campaign had colluded with Moscow.

A 2019 Justice Department special counsel report described wide-ranging Russian interference but found insufficient evidence to prove a criminal conspiracy between Russia and the Trump campaign.

Subsequent investigations by an Inspector General and Justice Department prosecutors identified errors by FBI agents but found no evidence of criminal wrongdoing by senior law enforcement officials nor proof of an anti-Trump conspiracy.

Frustrated by those outcomes, Mr. Trump has amplified his demands for retribution, calls the Justice Department heeded by directing that prosecutors use a grand jury. A team in Florida was assigned to hunt for a conspiracy.

Potential targets of the conspiracy investigation are unclear, though lawyers for Mr. Brennan have said they've been informed he's one.

Subpoenas for records or testimony have been issued during the course of the investigation to a broad array of former FBI and intelligence officials involved in the Russia case, including ex-national intelligence director James Clapper and Mr. Brennan, who was recently summoned to appear before the grand jury on October 15.

German automotive workers protest over jobs as industry faces upheaval

Agence France-Presse
FRANKFURT

German automotive workers held nationwide protests on Monday, calling for government and management action to protect jobs and factories as the car industry hits crisis point.

Growing Chinese competition, compounded by weak domestic demand and U.S. tariffs, has thrown the German car industry into crisis. Volkswagen plans to cut 1,00,000 jobs by the end of the decade, the biggest ever restructuring in automotive history. Mercedes-Benz and BMW are also downsizing.

Tens of thousands of people were expected to take part in the protests, which the IG Metall union said



At a crossroads: Workers protest against job cuts at Volkswagen's commercial vehicles plant in Hanover, Germany, on Monday. AFP

would take place at over 280 sites across Germany.

Speaking at VW's iconic Wolfsburg factory, the largest in the world by floor area, IG Metall leader and VW supervisory board member Christiane Benner said: “Things have really hit the fan.”

“Companies like VW, BMW, Audi, Bosch, Mer-

cedes and Porsche were synonymous with fantastic cars and high quality,” she said. “Now, management is driving the industry at full throttle into a brick wall.”

Many blame the industry's woes on the management for starting too late with the transition to electric vehicles and being too slow to invest in software.

Others point to Chinese government support for its domestic carmakers which many in Europe say has unfairly led to overcapacity in the global car industry.

Speaking after Ms. Benner, Daniela Cavallo, head of VW's works council, told workers some “painful” truths. “Europe's automotive industry will be remade,” she said. “Long-established carmakers will fall by the wayside. Others will have to merge.”

“The battle over how to share the burden has already begun,” she added. “The question is not what we as employees will be asked to take, but rather how we collectively can distribute sacrifices fairly amongst ourselves.”

Lingering loss



Holding on: People walk past homes damaged in last month's deadly flash flood and mudslide at Devighat in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Monday. The death toll from the disaster has crossed 1,450, while more than 6,000 people are still missing. REUTERS

Amnesty accuses M23 of abuses amounting to war crimes at Congo mines

Associated Press
DAKAR

Amnesty International accused M23 rebels in eastern Congo of carrying out abuses and unlawful killings of miners while trafficking critical minerals to neighbouring Rwanda, in what it said could amount to war crimes.

The Rwanda-backed rebels control dozens of artisanal mines in Congo's eastern North Kivu and South Kivu provinces, where tens of thousands of miners dig for minerals critical for much of the world's electronics, including mobile phones.

Amnesty International

said in its report on Monday it interviewed 26 people to document the crimes allegedly committed from January 2025 to March 2026, particularly at a coltan mine near Rubaya in North Kivu and a gold mine in Lomera in South Kivu.

‘Summary killings’

Sixteen of the interviewees, including miners and civilians, said the M23 rebels or security guards at the rebel-controlled mines had tortured or mistreated them, Amnesty's report said.

The rights watchdog said it documented abuses by the rebels that likely



Rwanda-backed M23 rebels control dozens of mines in Congo's North Kivu and South Kivu provinces. AP

amounted to crimes under international law, including “summary killings” – a

term used to describe killings outside of any legal framework – torture, arbitrary detention, forced labour and pillage.

The report detailed the

killings of 18 artisanal miners at the Rubaya and Lomera mines.

“Witnesses and family members reported that 10 were beaten to death, two were shot dead and six abducted miners were later found dead.”

Amnesty International also said it found evidence that gold was trafficked out of M23-controlled areas of eastern Congo into neighbouring Rwanda through smuggling routes.

The M23 and Rwandan authorities did not immediately respond to requests for comments.

United Nations experts, the United States and Congo's government have in

the past accused Rwanda of profiting off Congo's minerals in exchange for its support to the rebels, which Rwanda denies.

Humanitarian crisis

Eastern Congo, the mineral-rich part of the Central African nation, has for decades been ripped apart by violence from government forces and different armed groups, including M23, whose recent resurgence has escalated the conflict, worsening an already acute humanitarian crisis.

The Rubaya mine is a major coltan mining site that has seen numerous tragedies, including a mine collapse in March that

killed at least 200 people, and a landslide in January, which left around 200 people dead.

The Lomera gold mine suffered a collapse last year, trapping numerous miners.

Last year, Congo produced more than half of the world's tantalum – an ore derived from coltan used in smartphones among other products – with the Rubaya mine pumping out about 15% of global production, according to Amnesty International.

The country also exported more than 28 tonnes of gold that year, the group said.

INBRIEF



Spain extends de la Fuente's contract until 2032

Spain has agreed to extend the contract of World Cup-winning coach Luis de la Fuente until 2032. The Spanish football federation's board of directors unanimously approved the contract extension on Monday. The new contract will keep de la Fuente in for the 2030 World Cup that Spain will co-host with Morocco and Portugal, and the 2028 and 2032 European Championships. de la Fuente has won 38 of his 50 games in charge of the main squad.

Mandatory SRY gene test approved by AFI

The Athletics Federation of India (AFI) Executive Council has approved the decision to make Sex-determining Region Y (SRY) gene test mandatory for female athletes of all age groups from 2027. An athlete needs to pass the once-in-a-lifetime test in order to participate in all AFI-approved competitions, including domestic events, in the women's section.



Three-time Olympic swimming champ Burton passes away

Mike Burton, a three-time Olympic swimming champion who was the first American to win gold in the 1,500m freestyle at consecutive Games, has died. He was 79. Burton's historic repeat was overshadowed by teammate Mark Spitz winning a record seven gold medals, which occurred the day after Burton's race.



Evenepoel wins record fourth straight World time-trial title

Olympic champion Remco Evenepoel etched his name in the history books with a fourth successive World time-trial victory in Montreal on Sunday.

Spaun's day out at BMW PGA Championship

J.J. Spaun won the BMW PGA Championship on Sunday, making four birdies on the last five holes for a 5-under 67 and a two-shot victory in his debut at the European Tour's flagship event.

CSK names Zaheer as coach for IPL 2027

The former pacer replaces Fleming who had an 18-year stint; it remains to be seen whether his appointment is a short-term arrangement

CRICKET

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Chennai Super Kings (CSK) has appointed former India pacer Zaheer Khan as its head coach for IPL 2027. Zaheer replaces Stephen Fleming who guided the Men in Yellow from 2009 to 2026.

The former New Zealand skipper was removed from the job earlier this year after three poor seasons for the five-time champion, in which it failed to qualify for the playoffs.

Interestingly, Zaheer will be on a one-year contract.

With the mega auction set to take place before 2028, it remains to be seen if this is a short-term arrangement.

Zaheer has previously been part of the coaching set-up with Mumbai Indians and Lucknow Super



Zaheer. FILE PHOTO

Giants.

Rupa Gurunath, owner, CSK, said: "We are pleased to confirm Zaheer as the head coach. Zaheer's distinguished playing career and proven ability to nurture young talent make him a valuable addition to



It's an honour to be a part of one of the most successful teams in the the IPL. I can't wait to join the franchise with such a rich history

our set-up. We are confident that his guidance will help strengthen the core of the franchise."

K.S. Viswanathan, Managing Director, CSK, said Zaheer will have the freedom to choose his own support staff. "He's one of the finest cricketing brains, and we look forward to having him in our family."

Zaheer said: "It's an honour to be a part of one of the most successful teams in the IPL. I have faced CSK on the field and have thoroughly enjoyed the contests. The atmosphere created by the superfans at Chepauk makes it even more special. I can't wait to join the franchise with such a rich history".

Chance for India's emerging talent to enhance credentials

AUSTRALIA-A IN INDIA

Abhishek Saini
PUDUCHERRY

India's emerging First Class talent will strive to burnish its credentials even further as India-A hosts Australia-A in the first 'Test' at the Siam Cricket Stadium here, starting on Tuesday.

Devdutt Padikkal lived up to his billing with two hundreds in Sri Lanka last month and will lead the side, hoping to add to his growing reputation. B. Sai Sudharsan, who is returning after a foot injury, and Anshul Kamboj are the only other capped players in the squad.

The selectors have rewarded young batters Aman Mokhad, Ayush Pandey, Kumar Kushagra, and Shaik Rasheed for their domestic hauls. But India-A's only spin options, Shams Mulani and Tanush Kotian, are also all-rounders, and will probably squeeze out one outright batter at the top.

In the three First Class games at this venue last season, spinners picked 52 wickets at 23.32 while the quicks were limited to just 16 wickets at an average of more than 36. It is precisely why Australia-A has included Todd Murphy and



In the spotlight: Padikkal will look to continue his good form and lead from the front. FILE PHOTO: R. RAGU

Corey Rocchiccioli in its starting XI for the game.

The visitor also boasts of an experienced batting line-up in Peter Handscomb, Nathan McSweeney, Josh Philippe, and Sam Konstas, and most will take this series as an audition for the upcoming Border-Gavaskar Trophy in India early next year.

The teams (from): India-A: Devdutt Padikkal (Capt.), Sai Sudharsan (Vice-capt.), Aman

Tactical skills and Dhoni's nod seal the deal for Zaheer

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Chennai Super Kings (CSK) has been a symbol of stability, and it is often cited as a key reason for its success over the years. So, when the five-time champion parted ways with head coach Stephen Fleming after an 18-year long association earlier this year, there was suspense as to who would fill the New Zealander's shoes.

After months of deliberation, the team announced on Monday that Zaheer Khan will take over as head coach for 2027, and the decision clearly bears the imprint of former skipper M.S. Dhoni.

"We take all our decisions after discussing with Dhoni, and once he suggested his name, the management spoke to Zaheer and convinced him. Zaheer is also tactically strong, especially at figuring out the opposition's game plans. Rituraj Gaikwad and the players are excited to work with him," said CSK Managing Director K.S. Viswanathan.

The Yellow Brigade hasn't qualified for the



Great rapport: Zaheer and Dhoni share a close bond from their playing days. FILE PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK

playoffs since its title-winning run in 2023.

More importantly, the team had a poor mega auction in 2025 and is bearing the consequences of those missteps. Though some of them have been addressed, especially in the batting department, the line-up is still far from settled.

With one more year before the mega auction, the team needs to maximise its resources, and the management feels Zaheer can make an impact.

"We needed a coach who can gel well with the players, and Zaheer is the right choice for that. He is technically very strong and bowling is an area where

we felt we needed to improve.

"He can help our pacers like Khaleel Ahmed and Gurjapneet Singh," Viswanathan added.

Leader of the attack

During their playing days, Dhoni regularly heaped praise on Zaheer and relied on him as the leader of the bowling attack.

The former India skipper once even called him the Sachin Tendulkar of bowling.

The two have now come together again, albeit in different capacities, with a huge task ahead: to get the Super Kings back to their glory days, even if it's a long road.

Handscomb eyes Test return through the Australia-A route

Abhishek Saini
PUDUCHERRY

Peter Handscomb has been one of the highest run-scorers in Sheffield Shield in recent seasons and the 35-year-old said having a clear gameplan has helped him stand out of the pack.

"I've done a fair bit of work over the last four or five years on my technique and changing a few things. But also, the mental challenge and making sure that your gameplan is clear. It's something I've worked pretty hard on as well.

"Understanding where you can and can't score and what shots you can

and can't play on certain wickets. That's something that I've tried to be really strong at. I think that's helped me over the last few years," the Australia-A captain said ahead of the first 'Test' against India-A.

Handscomb, who last represented Australia in 2023, hopes a strong outing in the two-match series here can strengthen his bid for a Test return.

"I've done a lot in my career, but there's still stuff that I want to do.

"But I also understand that if those things don't happen, then it's not the end of the world. I'll still be pushing as hard as I can," he said.



Hungry for runs: Handscomb says having a clear gameplan has helped him. GETTY IMAGES

Uzbekistan hands India its first loss; women beat USA

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

In perhaps the most anticipated match at the Chess Olympiad, India went down to Uzbekistan 1.5-2.5 at Samarkand on Monday. It was not just the clash between the world's two strongest nations in terms of young chess talent, but the one between the defending champion and the host.

It was India's first defeat in the competition, after registering five consecutive wins. The Indian women, however, bounced back after their disappointing loss in the previous round; they beat the United States 3-1.

The much-needed victory was fashioned by Vanti-



Rising to the occasion: Vantika played a key role in India's win. FIDE

ka Agrawal and B. Savitha Shri, after Koneru Humpy and Divya Deshmukh drew their games on the top two boards. It was Savitha's fifth win in as many games; she was rested in India's defeat to Poland in the previous round. She beat Rose

Atwell, while Vantika overcame Irina Krush in a long game, converting her advantageous position with patience, in 65 moves.

In the open section, it was Nihal Sarin's defeat on the third board to Nodirbek Yakubboev that

proved costly for India. Nihal had been playing rather well though, until he blundered on the 37th move with his knight, after which he was doomed. He continued to wage a losing battle until he resigned on the 54th move.

The other games, including the one on the second board between Arjun Erigaisi and Javokhir Sindarov, were drawn. Going into Tuesday's rest day, India is in the joint second position in both the open and women's sections.

Important results (sixth round): Open: Uzbekistan bt India 2.5-1.5 (R. Praggnanandhaa drew with Nodirbek Abdusattorov; Arjun Erigaisi drew with Javokhir Sindarov; Nihal Sarin lost to Nodirbek Yakubboev; D. Gukesh drew with Shamsiddin Vokhidov).

China bt Germany 3-1; England drew with France 2-2; USA bt Norway 2.5-1.5; Armenia bt Iran 2.5-1.5; Azerbaijan bt Argentina 2.5-1.5; Uzbekistan (2) bt Spain 1.5; Hungary drew with Romania 2-2; Netherlands bt Israel 4-0; Bulgaria bt Ukraine 2.5-1.5; Uzbekistan (2) bt Spain 2.5-1.5; Switzerland bt Turkiye 3-1; Belarus drew with Poland 2-2; Greece bt Indonesia 3.5-0.5.

Women: India bt USA 3-1 (Koneru Humpy drew with Carissa Yip; Divya Deshmukh drew with Alice Lee; Vantika Agrawal bt Irina Krush; B. Savitha Shri bt Rose Atwell).

Georgia bt Uzbekistan 3.5-0.5; Kazakhstan bt Azerbaijan 2.5-1.5; China bt Poland 3.5-0.5; France bt Vietnam 4-0; Ukraine bt England 2.5-1.5; Germany bt Romania 2.5-1.5; Netherlands drew with Slovenia 2-2; Serbia drew with Turkiye 2-2; Mongolia bt Iran 3-1; Armenia bt Latvia 3-1; Belarus drew with Hungary 2-2.

Indu Puri chosen head of ad-hoc committee to administer TTFI

TABLE TENNIS

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

The Indian Olympic Association (IOA) has formally constituted a three-member ad-hoc committee to administer the Table Tennis Federation of India (TTFI), with former National champion Indu Puri appointed as its chairperson.

The office order, issued by IOA president P. T. Usha on September 17, comes a little over a month after the Sports Ministry suspended TTFI's recognition as the National Sports Federation on August 12. The IOA said

the committee had been constituted as a "limited and time-bound interim sporting mechanism" in consultation with the International Table Tennis Federation (ITTF).

Indu Puri, 73, an eight-time National champion, will be joined by Namrata Chatterjee, a reputed sports lawyer, as the legal member and Dr. Andres Constantin, ITTF Governance Manager, as the third member.

The committee's mandate includes ensuring the day-to-day administration of the sport, athlete participation and compliance with the applicable legal, regulatory and ITTF frameworks.

The committee has been tasked with ensuring uninterrupted functioning of TTFI, including athlete registrations, selections and entries, while maintaining neutrality and transparency. It has also been empowered, where necessary, to coordinate with government agencies and sporting authorities.

The committee has initially been constituted for six months.

Any extension will require a written IOA decision following consultation with, and prior written approval of, the ITTF. The IOA may also expand its strength from three to a maximum of five members, if required.



R.V. MOORTHY

Rudranksh — Indian shooting’s ‘chosen one’

The 22-year-old, who clinched bronze in 10m air rifle at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, has overcome a dark phase with constant learning and determination; the versatile shooter hopes to ‘complete the set’ at the 2028 Olympics

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Three years ago, Rudranksh Balasaheb Patil was being spoken of, in hushed but awed tone, as a possible successor to Abhinav Bindra.

The then 19-year-old’s performances and consistency had evoked admiration and hope in the shooting fraternity. But it all came crashing when he stumbled, finishing fourth in 10m air rifle at the 2023 Asian Games and failing to make the cut for the Paris Olympics – a quota he had held on to for two years after becoming the first Indian shooter to earn one. It wasn’t his skill that let him down; it was the mind. Still only 22, Rudranksh is now a lot more in control – of his mind, emotions, thoughts. That control saw him go one better on his disappointing Hangzhou outing, winning a bronze medal in 10m air rifle in Aichi-Nagoya.

Most importantly, the teenaged nervous energy has been replaced by a quietly confident one, a belief that he is good enough to succeed in not one but two events. He is representing India in both 10m air rifle and 50m rifle 3-Positions, the latter an addition after the Paris heartbreak in 2024.

Getting inspired

“As I see it, there are only a couple of athletes in the world who are doing well in two events. There are a lot of myths around balancing the two. When I started, there was a belief that if you do a second event, it will destroy your 10m form. There is also a thought that it’s difficult to manage both.

“But I was told by my nutritionist and psychologist that as long as you have two working legs and two working hands, you can do multiple events. That inspired me. And I saw Michael Phelps, who participated in multiple events and won multiple medals in all of them. So why not me? I have age on my side. I have a lot of years to make mistakes and learn through them,” the bespectacled youngster said in an exclusive interaction with *The Hindu* during the preparatory camp in Bhopal.

“This is the first Asian Games where I am participating in two events. It’s my fourth international competition doing so. Every time, I have improved a little bit. I have good coaches, good support staff. There is a lot of motivation. The hunger and greed is intact: if anything, it’s grown,” he added.

Content with third place

He has definitely learned. The bronze, which he clinched in 10m air rifle after leading for almost 70% of the competition here on Monday, might have been a disappointment at another time but for someone who has been in this position before, a medal was more than welcome.

“I am very happy with bronze because a lot of things could have gone wrong but all of it ended well. I would like to see the positives rather than the negatives,” he said.

Tough times

The aftermath of missing out on an Olympic outing was big, but for those around him more than himself. He hadn’t done badly: he finished third behind Arjun Babuta and Sandeep Singh in the trials.

“The sad part was seeing my parents and support staff. I was fine, honestly. My initial thought was: ‘I competed in 13 events and won 11. It’s just this one match that I lost, not a big deal’. But when I realised everyone was looking forward to that one match and were sad after watching me work hard, I was affected.

“I was actually sad because all the hard work which I had put in did not yield the result. But then, I started seeing the facts. It’s not that I was not selected because my score was bad: it was because one person shot a really high score. And I could not compete with that. Secondly, I always evaluate what I could have done better after a competition... the mistakes I made. But after that, I had nothing. I had given my best, my everything. I was able to figure things out and move forward.

“I started in a new event. My way of taking a break was getting back to shooting but it was on my terms. I used to go to the range but with no set schedule. I trained as I liked, whenever or however I liked... sometimes for hours, sometimes maybe for just 15 to 20 minutes. It was just a part of my life in which I had to be patient, I had to be persistent. I gradually built up my love for the sport again and started enjoying it,” Rudranksh explained the dark phase.

Finishing the job

There is also a determination to see his dreams, hard work and journey through to the end. It’s something that drives him, considering that the fear of leaving things midway has happened far too often for comfort.

“When I started my sporting journey, I was not exactly in a happy space in life. My marks (academics) were just fine. I was not good in other sports, I was new to the city and did not have many friends, I was lagging in everything. My parents used to get me some mechanical or Lego sets and I never completed any.

“It was a recurring complaint from my teachers that I was not completing anything. It became an obsession for me, it became a fixation that I want to do something in my life. I want to complete something. I started seeing athletes all over... Phelps. I had watched Bindra sir’s 2016 Olympics in Rio. All those sparked something in me. Even now, whenever things are not working out, I look around me for inspiration.

“A lot of athletes show up every day. Manu Bhaker, who is always on time, everywhere, always in the gym no matter what. Maybe, someone some day is as inspired by me as I am by others. That thought keeps me alive, gives me hope.”

He has learnt to stop worrying about things not in his control. Call it fate or luck, but Rudranksh prefers calling himself the ‘chosen one’ for all the unexpected setbacks he has faced, many of them not of his making. “I am kind of used to it by now. Even today (Monday), after my match was done, I picked up my rifle and the strap of the case broke. At the Peru World Cup, my gun auto-fired in the final and I was eliminated. Only my visa gets rejected,” he shrugged.

Showing maturity

The nervous, high-strung energy has settled into a quieter rhythm. It had helped him perform back then but had taken a toll on his health, both physical and mental. He suffered an auto-immune condition triggered by stress, messed up his sleep cycle and was desperate to continue regardless of everything – a lot like being on a high without drugs.

“When I lost, I would be down in the dumps. When I won, I used to feel like wanting to continue the streak no matter what – whether my sleep was affected, my hands were shaking, I was tired and ready to drop dead. Nothing mattered, only winning did. It has changed now but I am still learning how my body works. I learnt that fatigue is something which builds up during the Olympic time. I know I need to be more strategic and dissociated from the results.”

He knows he will make mistakes. He also knows that he will keep learning from them. Like Monday, when he admitted that slipping from No. 1 to No. 3 was largely his own doing – a poor 9.7 shot dashed his golden hopes.

“This gives me a kick, reminding me that I need to be calm till the last moment. I was too excited for the shot and I released before calming down. I think all the accumulated things over the last six months... perhaps it was just the way the body reacted once a medal was confirmed. The last time I spoke to you, I said I was looking to improve my rank, and that’s exactly what happened. Perhaps I need to watch what comes out of my mouth the next time,” he quipped.

External support

The support from the system has played a big role in his growth in 50m 3P. “The TOPS CEO then (Cmdr. P.K. Garg) was very supportive. He sanctioned my trip to Serbia for training with Olympic medallist Milenko Sebic. And he was impressed. The National coaches guided me on the right equipment, ammunition suppliers and provided the shots. Everything came together and in 2025, I participated in my first trials. I was in top-10, then top-6, now top-3. I hope to continue this.”

He is also aware that there is a long way to go. Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar, who beat him in the shoot-off for the 10m bronze medal in Hangzhou, is the top guy in 50m 3P. While Rudranksh insists that there is no rivalry between the two, he is clear on the strengths of both.

“I don’t and can’t compare myself with him in 3P because he is the best in the country for the past seven to eight years. This year, I was able to play with

him in three international tournaments: my aim every time was to score around 587 points while he shot above 590 in all. I don’t compare myself with him in 10m because I feel I am better. I have proved myself in it more than him and I have been in the 10m team for as long as he’s been in 3P. But yes, there are times when he shoots 10m better than everyone. In fact, he is also one of my inspirations to try two events – if he can do it, why can’t I?”

The Asian Games will help him complete the first set of targets he has set for himself, a list that, by his own admission, has grown in reverse. From being crowned the World champion in 10m air rifle in his maiden senior international outing in 2022 to winning his first National title earlier this year, Rudranksh’s journey has been interesting, to say the least.

“I won the World championship, then the World Cup Final, World Cups, got the World No. 1 title, the World Record. This year, I won the Asian championship for the first time after finishing fourth repeatedly. The only regret is that despite all this, I have not even been considered for an Arjuna Award so far. I even won my first National-level tournament this year. But there is the Olympics to complete the set, maybe they will recognise after that,” he signed off.



There is determination to see his dreams, hard work and journey through to the end. It’s something that drives him, considering that the fear of leaving things midway has happened far too often



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THE GIST

Rudranksh is now a lot more in control — of his mind, emotions, thoughts

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